

MAKSIM TEORENTER



DAYS IN CAPTIVITY

HOW TO SURVIVE HELL

A TRUE STORY OF SURVIVAL IN THE PRISONS
OF THE "DPR" STATE SECURITY MINISTRY. 2016-2019

1341 DAYS IN CAPTIVITY

How to Survive Hell

MAKSIM TEORENTER

Translated by Elizaveta Zinchenko

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Contact and purchase:

t.me/teorenter_bot

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FOREWORD

This book is the story of what many would call a person's worst nightmare. The loss of freedom, humiliation, torture, the fracturing of one's identity, the erasure of a former life and of oneself—this is not an experience that is easy even to read about. And it is certainly not something anyone needs to know in order to be prepared for it. No one should ever end up in such a situation, and no one should—or even can—be ready for it. It is an ordeal that destroys a life. And it destroyed mine.

Yet, when I think about why I still want to share what happened, I realize that this period became the defining chapter of my life. It was precisely this episode that forced me to completely reevaluate everything that had come before: my values, my priorities, and everything I believed about who I am and what I live for. A period of horrifying suffering turned out to be the most profoundly transformative time of my life. Had I not gone through it, I wouldn't be where I am now. Of course, at the time, I didn't see it that way—I thought each new day was so unbearable that I was ready to die.

And yet, surviving such agony can unlock a tremendous inner reserve.

On April 28, 2016, I was taken captive in the self-proclaimed Donetsk People's Republic on suspicion of spying for Ukraine. On December 29, 2019, through a prisoner exchange, I finally returned home. Between those two dates lay 1,341 days. Each one was a trial—physical, moral, and spiritual. I call this period my time “in isolation,” even though I wasn't always alone. For part of that time, I was surrounded by people, and at one point, I even became their leader. But in places like that, the people around you are not your friends, nor are they on your side. That realization—which came at a very high price—leaves you entirely alone with yourself.

Perhaps some will read this book simply as a gripping, first-person memoir based on true events. Perhaps others will look to it for techniques to strengthen their spirit. This book may be useful to those who, by profession or by fate, operate at the absolute limits of human endurance—in circumstances where you must dig deep to find inner resolve, accept defeat, and ultimately overcome it.

Or perhaps this will reach someone who has survived a similar nightmare and come out the other side. This is especially relevant now, when so many have faced something nothing could have

prepared them for: real combat. After an experience like that, a person—even if they survive, even if it's all over, even if they look fine on the outside—is wounded on the inside. A fracture has occurred, and they are likely struggling, often in vain, to come to terms with the fact that at some point, they faltered. That at some point, they lost the fight. For those who have been through this, I hope this book can serve as a key to healing. A guidepost showing which direction to walk in order to mend what is broken, find peace, and keep moving forward.

No one comes through this kind of experience unharmed. I believe the only thing that helped me cope better than others was my background in sports. I was an athlete, and the competitive spirit, the physical contact, and the discipline had hardened me. I was used to constantly pushing past my limits; I knew what it meant to fall and to lose, which meant I knew how to get back up after a defeat. Furthermore, my physical conditioning gave me a baseline of resilience. But in every other way, just like anyone else, I could not withstand it. I was not made of stone, and I could not endure the torture while keeping my dignity intact.

When a system's ultimate goal is to break a person, it will break them—one way or another. I was broken. I lived with that fracture until I finally managed to process that defeat within myself. Now, I can speak about it calmly, without shame,

recognizing what the experience actually gave me. If, after reading this book, you understand that no matter what has happened in your life, any internal ruin can be rebuilt—then I will have achieved what I set out to do.

1. ARREST

The morning of Maundy Thursday began with a nightmare—brutal and inescapable. In the dream, men were hacking at me with axes. Every blow echoed inside me not just as physical pain, but as a sharp premonition of approaching disaster, defeat, and tragedy. I woke up shattered, both physically and mentally. Fear had taken root in my chest. Replaying the dream in my mind, I thought it must be a warning that something terrible was about to happen. But I decided to go through with my plan anyway.

I, Maksim Teorenter, was born in the town of Krasny Lyman, in the Donetsk region, in 1981. My family was as ordinary as they come: my mother worked as an engineer at the railway station, and my father managed operations at a state farm. Life wasn't easy for either of them, though in different ways. Still, from my childhood, my father tried to instill in me a love for sports, a sense of responsibility, and even a certain heroic spirit, while my mother provided care, attention, and warmth.

When I was fourteen, Viktor Shepotko, a legendary Soviet coach and Master of Sports of Ukraine,

visited our school. It was the first time I had ever seen a living legend—a man whose strength and courage inspired incredible stories. I was in absolute awe. Confidence radiated from him. Inspired and without much hesitation, I enrolled in the Kolos youth sports school in Krasny Lyman, choosing strength sports: weightlifting, powerlifting, and kettlebell lifting. That's how I began taking athletics seriously, and it was there that I developed my core foundation: a habit of discipline and hard work. I can't say that weightlifting, or sports in general, came easily to me. I had to challenge my own weaknesses, learn mental fortitude, accept defeat, get back up after a fall, and keep pushing.

By the time I finished secondary school, I held the rank of Candidate Master of Sports. I was traveling for competitions, and my only desire was to pursue sports professionally and become a coach. For higher education, I chose the teaching program at the Donetsk National University of Physical Education and Sport. After graduating, I started working as a trainer at a local fitness club.



Donetsk Regional Championship in Combat Sambo. From the author's archive.

Once I entered the workforce, I quickly realized I had a dual nature: I was not just an athlete, but an entrepreneur. In 2011, I took the plunge into my first business venture. I leased a functioning fitness club from its owner, and within a year, I managed to triple its revenue. As I scaled the club, I taught myself marketing and advertising, eventually starting my own agency on the side. I transitioned into the agency full-time when the club's owner decided not to renew my lease, choosing instead to take back the now-lucrative business for himself. After the agency, I had the idea to build a facility

near the Krasny Lyman landfill for sorting solid household waste—plastic, glass, and metal—where it was separated, compacted, and shipped to processing plants.

That is what I was doing when 2014 hit—a turbulent, violent turning point. Donetsk descended into chaos; mass unrest broke out. Armed men took to the streets, blocked highways, and set up checkpoints between cities and even within specific districts of Donetsk itself. It reminded me of everything I had read about the 1917 revolution—the chaos, the violence, the murder, and the looting. Law enforcement effectively ceased to exist. The men manning the checkpoints did whatever they pleased: they drank, used drugs, and seized people's cars in broad daylight. Watching this grim repetition of history, I realized that conducting business here was no longer viable, and that the Ukraine I knew had ceased to exist in this territory.

When I met an intelligence officer named Vitaly Petrovich in 2015, we hit it off immediately. My competitive spirit and hunger for adrenaline pushed me to join the fight against those who had betrayed our flag and turned my city into a nightmare.

On April 27, 2016, I set out from Bakhmut for Maiorsk. The two towns were separated by 24 kilometers, which now served as the so-called border between Ukraine and the DNR. The entire route was one massive, agonizing line: people

dragging their belongings on foot, passengers trapped in cars for days at a time. In the past, this tree-lined stretch of road took five minutes to drive. Now, it was a corridor of pain, disappointment, and grief. People spent days and nights there; they died there and gave birth there. They vanished there, never to be found.

Right after passing through the Ukrainian checkpoint, I fell in step with an elderly couple, and we walked together toward Horlivka, near the DNR checkpoint at Maiorsk . Because I was traveling with them, no one paid me much attention. I was carrying a box containing a radiator—at first glance, just an ordinary space heater. But it was far from ordinary: it was an exact replica of the model installed in the building occupied by the head of the DNR, Alexander Zakharchenko, and it had been retrofitted with a hidden camera. My mission was to hand this device, along with a sum of cash, to an operative who would install it in the target room.

The Maiorsk checkpoint was nothing more than a trailer set up at a gas station, where soldiers checked passports and registered addresses. As I later found out, they were already waiting for me that day. Only a gut instinct, pushing me to act unpredictably, allowed me to slip through. At one point, while standing in line, I noticed no one was actively watching me, so I simply stepped out of line and merged with a group that had already cleared

passport control. A car was waiting for me on the other side, and it took me directly to Donetsk.

I stayed with a friend that night. We sat and talked into the evening, and when I went to sleep, the nightmare of the axes returned. Even the day before, a strange unease had been gnawing at me. Although I was in constant contact with the agent I was supposed to meet, a man named Dmitry, something kept me from fully trusting him. Still, the next morning, I got up and went to the rendezvous point to hand off the radiator and the cash.

Early on April 28, I arrived at the local radio market, "Motodrom ." The plan was simple: buy a phone, then meet Dmitry. But things didn't go according to plan. I bought the phone, but the exact moment I did, a white minivan screeched to a halt in front of me. Armed men in ski masks spilled out, swarmed me, and aggressively shoved me inside. They immediately yanked a bag over my head and bound my hands with tape. I quickly lost all sense of direction.

My first thought was: *This is the end.* I had been caught, which meant there had been a leak, and the operation was blown. Hundreds of scenarios raced through my mind. Fear gripped my throat, and despair washed over me. Yet, I fought with everything I had to keep a clear head—to analyze the situation, figure out how to survive, and get back home. Twenty agonizing minutes later, we

arrived at an undisclosed location.

They stood me against a wall and searched me. During the pat-down, they ripped off my cross—stripping away my symbol of faith and hope. Then, the intimidation began. They promised me unbearable suffering, threatening to slice off my ear or tear out my fingernails with pliers. I sank into a state of deep shock, a natural human response to such a horrifying reality. I knew these weren't empty threats; these were refined, brutal methods used by intelligence services. They know that terror is the most effective way to extract information, so they aim to break your psychological resilience immediately.

But alongside the shock and fear came a strange, chilling clarity. Standing on the precipice of complete mental exhaustion, I asked myself: *Was this fate?* My dream had been a warning. If I had heeded it, I could have changed the plan, taken a different route, and avoided capture. I began to blame myself for ignoring my intuition. At the same time, I remembered the emotions that drove me to proceed: a sense of duty, the absolute need to complete the mission, and a conviction that faith in my cause mattered more than my fear.

Now, years later, I realize that the dream was both a warning and an indicator of the trial I was destined to face—a test of my faith in myself and my purpose. Yes, I could have changed my fate. But today, I don't

regret my choice, because it led me through the darkest, most intense, and ultimately most valuable period of my life.

2. HELL ON EARTH

They put me on an iron table. My legs were tied to the corners, my torso lashed to the metal surface with thick rope. They pulled off my socks, wound exposed wires around my toes, and poured water over my feet. That was the moment I realized something terrible was coming—a level of cruelty I hadn't even known existed. The first jolt of electricity threw me into violent convulsions. It felt as if my entire body was contracting into a single, screaming knot of agony. I shrieked the way an animal shrieks in a slaughterhouse.

“Do you know what my name is?” one of the torturers asked, leaning close to my face.

I shook my head.

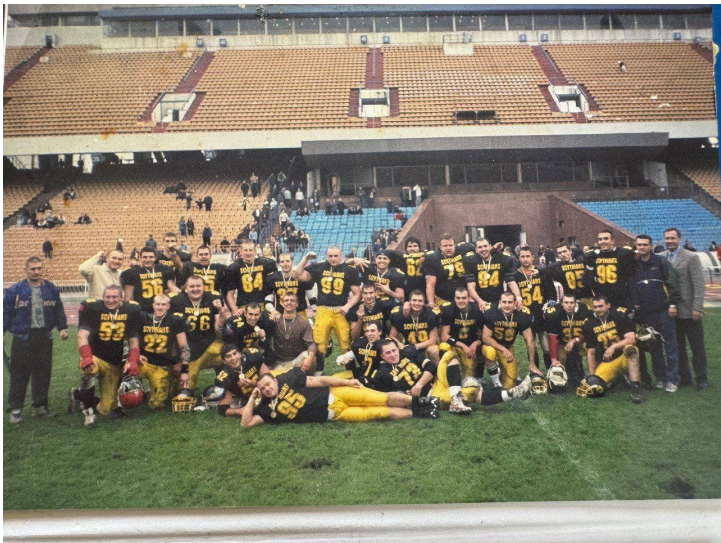
“My name is Hades. And you are in hell,” he said.

I believed him. Because what followed truly was hell on earth, and I was its captive.

Up until that day, I had considered myself a strong man—someone whose character and willpower were forged in the fires of competitive sports. Athletics had always been more than just self-expression; it was a tool for shattering my own

limitations. On the field, just as in life, you learn to work as a team, push through pain, and see things through to the end, even when victory seems impossible.

In my second year of university, I decided to try American football—a choice that seemed completely inexplicable, even to me. I joined the *Donetsk Skify*, and together we won the Ukrainian championship and the CIS Cup. Later, playing for the Scouts in Chelyabinsk, I took silver at the Russian championship. It was in American football that I earned the rank of Master of Sports.



The American football team. From the author's archive.

After feeling I had run my course in football, I transitioned to combat sports. Within six months, I

won the Ukrainian grappling championship in Kharkiv. International tournaments followed, along with a deep dive into sambo and pankration. Sports had frequently been my refuge during difficult times. Every training session was a reminder that I could conquer obstacles. Every victory was a triumph over myself, my fears, and my doubts.

But no amount of training could have prepared me for this. Nothing can prepare a human being for the torture chamber.

My body became a battleground of unbearable torment. My first reaction was pure, primal rage—like a bull charging the matador who has come to kill it. I screamed insults at my captors, calling them every filthy name I could think of. But that defiance burned out quickly. After half an hour, there was no fight left in me. The pain was tearing me apart from the inside out.

Chained to the iron table, I felt the crushing weight of my own helplessness. A despair unlike anything I had ever known consumed me. I begged, I pleaded for it to stop, but my voice carried no willpower—only the raw echoes of horror. They told me it would only get worse if I didn't cooperate, detailing the atrocities they planned to inflict on me. I writhed and struggled so violently that I actually tore through the ropes and crashed to the floor. They were on me in seconds, beating me mercilessly before strapping me back down. Then,

one of the men calmly stated that he already knew everything, and began listing the highly classified details of my operation.

That's when it clicked: they had my agent. They knew it all.

Try to imagine the depth of dread when physical pain becomes so absolute that the very concept of being alive feels intolerable. Every passing second is a trial; every breath requires monumental effort. In that state, a gaping void replaces your heart, and your mind is filled with nothing but a silent, endless scream. Your brain desperately searches for a way out of the reality, while your body surrenders its will to survive. The conflict between the instinct for self-preservation and the desperate desire to simply die tears your soul to shreds.

I've heard that some people in these situations skip the anger phase entirely and go straight to weeping. I believe it. The moment that first current hits your body, all heroism evaporates. I will never believe anyone who claims they endured this kind of physical torment without breaking. Torture destroys everyone.

The pain hijacked every cell in my body, reverberating through my joints and muscles. The ropes were tied so tight they cut off my circulation; my hands felt like dead, foreign objects detached from my arms. I tried to twitch my fingers, but they wouldn't obey. With every strike, my body

resonated like the hollow body of a guitar being smashed against the floor. My ears rang so violently that the entire world shrank down to that single, piercing frequency. A faint inner voice begged me to hold on, but my flesh was screaming for release.

The pain is so unbearable I would rather die, I thought.

But then Hades leaned in and whispered, “You’re not going to die right now. We’re going to keep you right on the edge, so you feel the absolute depths of suffering.”

This was an alternate reality. The masked men carrying out the torture were mere puppets executing someone else’s sick will. When they threatened me or laughed, there was no hot malice in their eyes, nor any compassion—only dead, cold indifference.

Those hours were so saturated with agony that human language fails to capture them. The sensations were so sharp that the boundary between the physical and the spiritual completely dissolved. Unless you have lived it, you cannot comprehend it.

Under the relentless pressure of the interrogation—which included electrocution, suffocation with a plastic bag, burning cigarettes pressed into my skin, slashing my heels, and brutal beatings—I broke. The tension became so unbearable that a fundamental wire inside my brain

just snapped. I started talking. I told them everything about myself, vomiting up names and details I thought I had forgotten years ago. The trauma acted like a horrifying truth serum.

By my estimate, the active torture lasted about eight hours. The whole time, a fractured dialogue echoed in my head. One part of my mind pleaded with me to hold on, while another condemned me, repeating: *How could you give in?* The interrogators kept reminding me they already had the facts; I just needed to confirm them to save my life. I tried to withhold key pieces of information, to maintain some line of defense, but exhaustion made me sloppy. Every micro-hesitation, every stutter, signaled to my torturers that I was hiding something. And every time I hesitated, they hit me with the electricity.

I was so ground down that I would have confessed to anything just to make it stop. If they had asked me to confess to assassinating JFK, I would have signed the paper. That is how systematically they dismantle the human spirit.

"I'm ready to confess," I finally choked out.

With heavy sighs, they unstrapped me, hauled me up, and dragged me to another room where a video camera was set up. My legs felt like rubber; my entire nervous system was one raw, exposed wire. The universe collapsed down to the chair and the lens in front of me.

Stammering and terrified, I recorded my "confession" over and over again. Every cell in my body violently rejected what I was saying, but the horror forced the words out. I couldn't think clearly. I felt like I was speaking my own death sentence. I knew this moment would haunt me forever—a heavy, indelible stain on my dignity.

After they got their video, they dragged me to the basement and threw me into a solitary cell, ten meters by five. They came for me four more times that day, each visit ending in violence. Later, they moved me to a cell where sleep was impossible. The harsh lights stayed on 24/7, and through the walls, I could hear the muffled groans of another prisoner being destroyed by this insane system. Finally, they tossed me into a punishment cell.

My body was failing. The paralyzing dread of the next beating tore at me from the inside. Having repeated my forced confession so many times, the words had lost all meaning. I was actively losing my grip on who I was. When the cell finally went quiet at night, I closed my eyes, praying for death. Opening my eyes and realizing I was still in hell was agonizing.

On Easter Sunday, they came for me again, announcing they needed to verify the "sincerity" of my confession. I had nothing left to give; I had told them everything. But it became terrifyingly clear that my torturers were now just doing it for sport.

They derived a twisted, sadistic pleasure from the abuse. My soul was hollowed out. I begged them to just end my life.

After that session, I was dumped back into the basement, which remained my tomb for the next thirty days.

That month was a masterclass in suffering. I learned exactly where the limits of human endurance lie. The beatings left me crippled; I could barely shuffle my feet, and every micro-movement was agony. I could feel my humanity slipping away. I was hovering on the threshold of becoming something feral, something less than human.

Two weeks in, they brought me to an investigator to officially document my confessions. At that point, my only wish was to be transferred to a standard prison. But my pleas were ignored. The nightmare dragged on. When I was arrested, I weighed 96 kilograms and was in peak physical condition. Ten days later, I had lost nearly 25 kilos. My clothes hung on me in bloody rags. I was unrecognizable.

My mind began to fracture into delirium. One day, I hallucinated that Death itself had entered my cell—a literal cloaked figure with a scythe. Strangely, I wasn't afraid. Death felt like a friend. It sat beside me, and we stared in silence at the prison walls. But then, something else slipped into my mind. A cold, foreign parasite made of pure dread. It infected my thoughts, hijacking my internal monologue. I

realized my mind was no longer entirely my own; it had been occupied by the trauma.

My identity and pride were completely annihilated. I was reduced to a pathetic, terrified shadow of my former self. It wasn't just a loss of self-esteem; it was a mortal wound to the soul.

But amidst the endless blackness, there was one fleeting moment of grace. One day, a guard at the checkpoint handed me a cup of water and whispered:

“Hold on.”

That single, simple spark of humanity pierced the darkness.

Drawing on my years of sports training, I began doing minuscule physical exercises in my cell to try and rehabilitate my broken body. With every painful stretch, I tried to summon the ghost of the athlete I used to be. In the deepest depths of hell, I started searching for a way back to myself.

3. TERRORIST NUMBER ONE

On Sunday, May 22, 2016, I woke up with a deep, inexplicable sense of dread. The nightmare had returned. Only this time, after the torture, Alexander Zakharchenko himself stood over me and ordered my ear to be cut off. (I had never actually met Zakharchenko, even though I was officially charged with attempting to assassinate him and overthrow the constitutional order of the DNR).

Around ten in the morning, the guards came. They bagged my head, handcuffed me, and threw me into a vehicle. When we arrived at our destination, I was marched up to the second floor. As I entered a large room, a chorus of voices erupted. One man yelled that he recognized me from my fighting career; another promised to electrocute me; a third threatened to carve me into pieces. A fourth voice told the others to back off, ominously adding that I had no idea what was waiting for me. Through it all, I stood blind and handcuffed, unable to defend myself.

Suddenly, the room fell dead silent. A voice cut through the quiet—Zakharchenko's voice. He

ordered them to pull the bag off my head.

I blinked against the light. We were in a room about six meters by four. Behind a desk sat Zakharchenko himself, draped in military medals and flanked by masked gunmen. To my right, a table was covered with disassembled weapons. Loud Cossack music blared from a speaker. But what shocked me most was the sheer number of Orthodox icons covering the walls.

I grew up in an environment where faith and tradition commanded deep respect, fundamentally rooted in love for one's fellow man. But since my capture, the stories I had heard about the "devout Orthodox Christians" of the DNR made it impossible to reconcile those icons with the reality of this room.

The prison guards often bragged about a unit of Cossacks who styled themselves an "Orthodox Army." They controlled a checkpoint in the Maiskyi district of Donetsk. According to the rumors, the woods near their checkpoint were filled with fresh, unmarked graves. The bodies belonged to innocent civilians, murdered simply because these "holy warriors" wanted their cars or cash.

I knew similar stories firsthand. One involved a prominent, respected business family who had invested heavily in the local community. Masked men dragged them from their home in the dead of night, brought them to the exact torture chamber I

was in, and systematically brutalized them until they signed over every asset they owned. Another victim was a modest restaurant owner who had poured his life savings into his business. After a few days on the iron table, he surrendered the deed just to escape with his life.

Our facility was a black hole for the city's entrepreneurs. It didn't matter if you owned a kiosk or a conglomerate—any night, your door could be kicked in. Donetsk used to be a proud, industrial hub built by hardworking business people. Now, material wealth meant nothing; survival was the only currency. The greed of thugs had turned my city into a bloodbath.

"How could someone from the Donetsk region do the things you've done?" Zakharchenko sneered, leaning forward, trying to stare straight through me.

I had been warned he wanted to look the man who "tried to kill him" in the eye, especially since I was a local. But it wasn't curiosity driving him; it was pure malice. He began detailing exactly how he was going to destroy me—how my guts would be wrapped around a wheel, how my limbs would be torn off. Every syllable was designed to terrorize me.

He phrased his question as if my birthplace meant I owed him my loyalty. But I never had an identity crisis. Even though I spoke Russian, I always knew I

was Ukrainian. My sports career cemented that. I had stood under the blue and yellow flag too many times, fought on the mat for the right to hear my national anthem, to ever betray it. When the armed mobs took over in 2014, screaming utopian, contradictory slogans —“ Loot the looters!”, “Donetsk will be Switzerland!”, “For the Russian World!”—my choice was clear. These men were bringing nothing but darkness.

That is why I went behind enemy lines. Because I had a Donetsk residency permit, I could slip through checkpoints undetected. I gathered intel, monitored DNR leadership, and recruited assets for Ukrainian intelligence. Working in espionage felt familiar; it mirrored the high-stakes chess match of combat sports. I had a clear opponent.

But there is nothing more dangerous than a neighbor turned enemy.

Looking at Zakharchenko, I felt no respect. He carried himself like a street thug who had won the lottery, not a head of state. He possessed no ideals, no principles. He was simply a byproduct of the chaos, a man who manipulated fear to cling to power. My only emotion toward him was profound contempt.

Zakharchenko laid out my future with gleeful certainty. He promised to throw me into a cell with late-stage tuberculosis patients where I would "rot to death." When he finished his gruesome

monologue, he signaled his guards. "Show him the dolphin."

They dragged me down into a basement. With every creak of the wooden stairs, the damp, freezing air seemed to carry the screams of the men who had walked this path before me. The atmosphere was suffocating.

They pinned me to the cold tile floor. The guards held my limbs down with predator-like strength. They draped a piece of light, seemingly harmless gauze over my face. Then, a man stepped forward with a jug of water.

Waterboarding is an instrument of pure panic. As the water soaked the cloth, it suctioned to my nose and mouth like a brand. Every attempt to breathe pulled water into my lungs. My brain spun out of control; sheer, animalistic terror hijacked my nervous system.

They pushed me to the brink of drowning, revived me, and immediately did it again. Three times they drowned me. By the end, I was a hollowed-out husk. Then they dragged me to a large tub of water and pushed my head under, holding me there until my lungs spasmed. For the grand finale, they fired a handgun inches from my ear, rupturing my hearing and leaving me deeply concussed.

Through the ringing in my ears, one of them laughed and asked who was "tougher"—the DNR, or the Ukrainian agencies I had worked for. I told them

they were tougher. It was what they wanted to hear.

When they hauled me back up to Zakharchenko's office, his rage hadn't subsided. He screamed like a man possessed. Reaching a crescendo of hatred, he gave the order: cut off his ear, or chop off a finger.

This is it, I thought.

My soul seemed to detach from my body to spare itself the incoming trauma. I dissociated entirely, hovering outside myself, watching these monsters prepare to mutilate my physical shell. I tried to convince myself it was just a nightmare.

They dragged me toward the stairs, but just as my foot hit the top step, a voice barked from down the hall: "Stand down!"

Immediately, the guards spun me around, marched me out to a car, and drove me back to my isolation cell. Was it a sudden change of plans? Divine intervention? I will never know what saved me from the blade that day.

Back in my cell, Hades—also known as Palych—strolled in. He wasn't in a hurry. He looked incredibly amused, clearly already briefed on my audience with the leadership.

"So, how'd the meeting go? Tell me," he asked, his voice dripping with sadistic mockery.

My heart sank. The memories of the waterboarding clawed at my brain. He was practically vibrating with the desire to hear me describe my humiliation.

"You're our terrorist number one now," he smirked. The words hit me like a bucket of ice water.

In my past life, I earned titles through blood, sweat, and discipline. I fought to be the best, and my medals were symbols of honor. But in this dark, twisted underworld, I had just been awarded a very different kind of title. My face was plastered across their propaganda channels; the label was stamped onto my forehead. I had been dragged into a criminal hierarchy I wanted no part of.

But this new "medal" had two sides.

Being dubbed "Terrorist Number One" made me a high-value trophy. Inside the prison hierarchy, I became an object of fear, which afforded me a tiny sliver of protection from the general population. However, it also meant the guards would never take their eyes off me. I was completely cut off from the outside world—no packages, no communication, no mercy. In sports, climbing the ranks brings glory. Here, my high profile could easily get me killed.

How do you survive a label like that? You accept it. I tried to use my new status as fuel: *I am strong enough to carry this. I will survive.* But deep down, all I wanted was to strip off the heavy armor and return to a normal life.

The rest of my time in isolation was like a macabre *Groundhog Day*. Every morning was a carbon copy of the torture from the day before. The endless, cyclical nature of the abuse bred a suffocating

anxiety within me. Time stopped making sense. Without a window or a clock, the delivery of breakfast and dinner were my only anchors to reality. A single day could stretch out to feel like a century.

To cope, my brain escaped into alternate realities. Sometimes, I visualized myself sprouting wings and flying over the prison walls, feeling the sun on my face and the wind in my hair. Other times, I imagined I was a James Bond-style spy, using high-tech gadgets to silently dispatch the guards and walk out the front door. At night, I tried to consciously program my dreams, desperate for a subconscious sign that my rescue was imminent.

Honestly, during those early months of isolation, my brain simply refused to accept that this was real life. I kept waiting to wake up in my own bed. The relentless physical trauma and psychological warfare had fractured my identity so thoroughly that my daydreams became my only sanctuary. They kept my mind from shattering completely. They kept the smallest, weakest spark of freedom alive in the absolute dark.

4. ESCAPE

Eventually, I was moved to a cell with two other men, both held on trumped-up espionage charges. Nikolai, a Donetsk native, was tangled up in a case involving video surveillance. Hara had been caught transporting contraband and was awaiting extradition from the DNR. Essentially, the three of us were political prisoners. Because of that, we quickly found common ground—or at least, that's how it seemed to me at the time.

Seeing how rapidly my mental state was deteriorating, Hara agreed to help. He had a few days left in Donetsk before his extradition. I asked him to call a trusted contact as soon as he was back in the city, explain everything, and pass along a letter to ensure it reached the right hands. The letter stated that I was alive, that I had a window to escape, and that I needed someone to meet me at a specific time and place. Hara was then supposed to send a reply hidden in a care package, confirming the plan and providing addresses where I could lay low. That was the plan.

This escape plan was no longer just an idea; it was

an absolute necessity. The physical and emotional agony had become so unbearable that I was right at the breaking point. I felt like a noose was tightening around my neck a little more every day.

After I joined Nikolai and Hara, the three of us were regularly taken out for forced labor. There was a military warehouse on the grounds of our torture facility, and they used us to load ammunition. Next to the warehouse was a three-story building, and in front of it was a clearing with a table where we were fed. Beyond that was a fence.

I quickly realized the compound wasn't as secure as I had assumed. You could see the street through the fence, and every time I looked at it, the temptation to vault over and run was overwhelming. But we were heavily guarded; a direct sprint was suicide. One day, however, they brought us inside the building, and I noticed that several of the plastic windows still had their handles attached. Opening a window and jumping out suddenly struck me as a highly realistic option.

That was how my escape plan took shape. I mapped it out carefully, studying the grounds and memorizing the route. Every new day in that cell was torture, but each day cemented my certainty that I had to take this desperate risk.

Outwardly, I projected fearlessness. I built a stone wall around myself, never allowing a single crack of weakness to show. To my cellmates and the guards,

I probably seemed entirely devoid of emotion. But inside, I was carrying an enormous trauma. When the lights went out and I was left alone with my thoughts, the stone walls crumbled. Memories of my freedom, my family, and my friends cut into my heart like knives.

Every second of captivity was saturated with pain. Day by day, my body grew more emaciated, covered in a shifting map of fresh bruises and scars. But the psychological abuse tormented me far more—a twisted game of cat and mouse where I was the helpless victim. I had been stripped of everything: freedom, pride, and dignity. I was a living target for their mockery and sadism. Every morning heralded a new circle of hell. I could feel myself disappearing.

Yet, every time I felt I was about to shatter, every time my strength evaporated and I was ready to surrender, I found something deep inside that forced me to keep breathing. It was a spark of hope—a stubborn belief that one day this would end and I would be free. Sixty days of systematic abuse had compressed the last remaining fragments of my willpower into cold resolve. I had to try to escape.

But fate had other plans, adding one more trial to my list: betrayal.

The day after Hara and I finalized the plan, our cellmate Nikolai was called in to see the investigator. As I found out later, he exposed everything. The intel went straight to the top of the

Ministry of State Security, and the Minister himself personally ordered them to deal with me. That same day, without explanation, I was dragged to a punishment cell. That evening, Hades (Palych) walked in and delivered a simple message: “You’re finished.”

I was shoved into a narrow concrete box, about a meter and a half by a meter. The harsh light stayed on 24/7. There was zero ventilation, and a camera watched my every move. I knew something had gone catastrophically wrong. My eyes locked onto a message someone had scratched into the wall: “*If you ended up here, your life is over.*”

Those words carved themselves into my soul. A freezing wind seemed to pass over my skin. I knew the man who had written that message—Oleg Chulga. He had survived thirty days of isolation in this exact room, and knowing that made me realize the full gravity of my situation.

Oleg, arrested for spying for Ukraine, had been tortured with exceptional cruelty. They once put him in a coffin, nailed it shut, and staged a mock burial to make him believe he was about to be buried alive. That specific brand of psychological torture is designed to annihilate a person’s spirit and instill absolute helplessness.

Looking at his words, a crushing weight settled over me. I knew the same horrors were waiting for me. But strangely, Oleg’s graffiti also became a source of

hope—proof that even in the darkest abyss, the human spirit is capable of enduring.

The days blurred into one endless, agonizing loop. I was trapped inside my own mind. Memories of the past, and an obsessive need to figure out where the plan had derailed, plagued every second. Unanswerable questions bubbled up from the depths of my consciousness: *Why? How did this happen? Where did I go wrong?*

The thoughts bit into me like venomous snakes, dragging me deeper into doubt and agony. I paced from corner to corner, desperate for a way out of the nightmare. It felt as if everything bright and good in my life had been extinguished. Absolute hopelessness infected every cell of my body.

One day, when I had stopped expecting anything, the heavy door swung open. A massive guard nicknamed "Fat Man" blocked the threshold. Tall and incredibly powerful, he reminded me of a bear.

"Someone wants to talk to you," he grunted. He yanked a bag over my head, tied my wrists behind my back, and marched me down the corridor to the central room.

The moment my feet stopped moving, the first blow landed. Without warning, they swarmed me, striking from every direction—my legs, my back, my head. Every hit was punctuated by a question: "Think you're James Bond?" "Thought you'd escape?" "Nobody leaves here alive, do you understand?"

I lost my balance and crashed to the floor. They dragged me back up and kept hitting. Soon, I couldn't feel my legs; my entire nervous system became one continuous sheet of white-hot pain. My universe shrank down to the suffocating black fabric of the bag and the disembodied voices screaming out of the dark.

Later, lying broken on the floor of my cell, the reality of my situation finally crushed me. I realized the utter futility of fighting back. But worst of all was the agonizing sting of betrayal by a man I thought I shared a fate with. In that moment of absolute weakness and total despair, I experienced hopelessness in its purest, most brutal form.

It felt as though a piece of my soul hadn't just been wounded—it had been ripped out by the roots. The physical pain was relentless. I couldn't stand; I couldn't even lift my arms. As the agony radiated through me, I blamed myself. I blamed God. I blamed all of humanity. Thoughts of Nikolai's betrayal filled me with a toxic, unquenchable thirst for revenge.

In hindsight, I realized that what I perceived as calculated betrayal was actually a tragic misalignment of motives. Because all three of us were political prisoners, I had blindly assumed we were on the same team. But every person has their own agenda, their own threshold for pain, and their own dilemma about how to survive.

Nikolai didn't betray a pact, because we never actually made one. He wanted to stay in Donetsk, where his family and friends lived. He simply used the intel he had to buy himself favor with the administration. Looking back, I remembered the look in his eyes as he lay on his bunk, listening to Hara and me plot. I hadn't paid attention. Even though he was physically in the room, my mind had treated him as if he were asleep.

That was my fatal mistake. We both falsely assumed we shared the same values. In reality, we were operating on hidden motives and unspoken expectations. It was a brutal lesson in how to choose my allies, how to gauge true intentions, and how to guard my own boundaries.

But lying on that concrete floor, I only wanted revenge. I was disgusted by the realization that even among prisoners, there was no unity against the common enemy. In that agonizing state, I knew I had to find fuel somewhere if I was going to survive. I realized that physical endurance wasn't enough; I needed an inner reserve of faith and hope. Without it, I was vulnerable not just to physical destruction, but to spiritual death.

I knew I couldn't survive in a state of endless psychological torment. Even in this hellscape, I had to find a way to achieve inner peace.

5. THE BIBLE

The next morning, a doctor came in to examine my cuts and fractures. His tired eyes scanned the fresh landscape of scars on my body while his hands professionally checked my reflexes and pulse.

“How are you feeling after yesterday?” he asked, avoiding my gaze. His voice was entirely detached.

I tried to lift my arm, but the pain flared violently.

“I don’t know... I feel like I went ten rounds with a bull,” I whispered.

He nodded, a silent acknowledgment of the brutality.

“I gave you a heavy painkiller. It should help. You’re lucky—no internal injuries.”

I tried to smile, but my lips were split and swollen.

“Thank you,” I rasped. “What happens now?”

The doctor sighed and didn’t answer. I closed my eyes and focused on my breathing. A chaotic flood of thoughts spun through my mind until, without realizing it, I slipped into unconsciousness.

When I woke up, the sharpest edges of the pain were gone. My legs felt like lead blocks, completely paralyzed, but I didn’t care. The doctor’s injection

had knocked me out for twelve hours, and I had slept like a baby. Looking down at my limbs—mottled in every shade of purple, black, and green—I realized that, miraculously, my bones were intact. For that, I was grateful, not just to the doctor, but to my years in sports. Athletics had built me a suit of muscular armor. It was a small victory, but a vital one in the endless night of my captivity.

I couldn't get out of bed for a full week. My legs simply refused to hold my weight. My cellmate had to hand me a plastic bottle for my basic needs and empty it for me. I was shedding weight rapidly, feeling my strength siphon away a little more every day. I had never experienced such profound physical weakness in my life. Pain was my constant companion, but the mental exhaustion was even worse.

One day, Hades brought an FSB officer into my cell with news from the outside world. He told me my handlers had burned me. My business had been seized and carved up by my own partners. My friends had abandoned me. My girlfriend had left me for someone else.

Worst of all, he told me my parents were selling the apartment they had spent their entire lives working for. They were selling the garage, their jewelry, everything they owned, desperately trying to buy my freedom—but it wouldn't work. The FSB officer sneered that they were just handing their life

savings to con artists.

I knew this might be psychological warfare, a lie designed to finish breaking me. (As I found out later, it was all entirely true). Regardless, the words hit me like a sledgehammer. The isolation was complete. I was utterly alone.

They say sometimes you have to die to find out who is truly alive. In that cell, that proverb became my ultimate truth about human nature. How often do we surround ourselves with friends, convinced of their loyalty? The real picture only emerges when you are backed against a wall, completely stripped of your power and utility.

Many of the people I had considered close friends showed zero sympathy. At best, they turned away, unwilling to get tangled up in my "problems." At worst, they actively exploited my absence for their own gain. It was a devastating blow, but a necessary lesson. From that point on, I learned to cherish the few who stayed loyal, and to look at the rest of the world with clear, discerning eyes, understanding that true motives are almost always hidden behind social masks.

Yet, in a world where relationships are increasingly transactional, where friendship is measured in social media metrics, a few people showed me the absolute pinnacle of human decency. One of those people was Roma Svyat.

While I was locked in isolation, no one could help

me directly. But Roma stepped in and anchored my parents. He supported my mother through her darkest hours, visiting her every day, sharing stories, offering kind words, and keeping her hope alive. He acted as a lifeline, helping my parents carry the crushing weight of my absence. To my mother, he became the very definition of a true friend.

Later, when I was moved to the penal colony and could occasionally smuggle out a message, Roma was the one who coordinated everything. He collected funds and organized care packages. When you are buried alive in a prison system, knowing there is someone on the outside who will actually answer the phone and take action—rather than offering empty excuses about being "too busy" with their own family—is priceless. Roma never asked for a reward or even a thank you. He simply did what was right. Loyalty like that is worth more than gold.

But in the immediate aftermath of the FSB officer's visit, I spent my days and nights mourning the death of my old life. The moment they locked me in the basement, the man I used to be ceased to exist.

The grief was destructive. I replayed every mistake, every cruelty, every misstep I had ever made. I summoned the ghost of everyone who had ever crossed my path; I held conversations with them in my head, tried to understand them, and begged for their forgiveness. I dismantled my entire life, piece

by piece. This was my purgatory—the place where I was forced to sit in the dark with my deepest fears and deepest regrets.

I knew that if I didn't find an anchor soon, my mind would consume itself. I needed to save my soul.

On the fourth day of my captivity, a guard had tossed a Bible into my cell. It was likely intended as a psychological taunt, a subtle reminder to start praying before the real horrors began.

Unexpectedly, that massive book offered me the one thing I desperately needed: silence. It was a breath of fresh air. I threw myself into the pages like a dying man at an oasis. I devoured the entire book in a week, then flipped to the Book of Revelation and read it backward to Genesis.

Prisons are full of Bibles, and full of God. When a person loses everything that gave their life meaning, when every worldly pillar collapses, the instinct to search for divine answers is inevitable. Even when all other literature is banned, the Bible is permitted. In solitary confinement, it becomes the only entity you can converse with. Reading it genuinely stabilizes a fractured mind.

I found a certain peace in those pages. Reading about agony, sin, and deliverance, I searched the text for the root cause of my own downfall. But while the Bible provided a framework for understanding the world, it also triggered a profound internal conflict.

The Old Testament filled me with dread. It is a harsh, brutal text governed by the absolute law of an eye for an eye. In my fragile state, reading it convinced me that my current torture was divine retribution. I pictured myself as the ultimate sinner, paying the blood price for my past recklessness. Evil breeds evil. I desperately wanted to survive, but the Old Testament offered no quarter.

The New Testament, however, opened the door to a completely different universe—one built on love, forgiveness, and humility. It offered a soothing promise: if I acknowledged my sins, I would be granted a second chance. That hope became my anchor in the storm. Yet, at the same time, the New Testament's teachings felt deeply disempowering. The constant demand to *submit to the will of the Lord, for everything is in His hands* stripped me of my agency. It demanded passive obedience in the face of slaughter.

As someone who identified as an Orthodox Christian, this dichotomy—vengeance versus forgiveness, wrath versus submission—forced me into a theological crisis. I realized my faith carried a dangerous duality. It elevated fear and self-sacrifice to the highest spiritual ideals, acting simultaneously as a comfort and a chain. The scriptures constantly demanded I be a "servant of God," but my soul violently rejected the concept of servitude.

I began to view the Bible not just as a spiritual

guide, but through a historical lens. It was a compilation of texts assembled for specific purposes—a tool for governance and social control, designed to steer the masses.

Despite my skepticism, the Bible gave me exactly what I lacked: faith in something greater than my cell, and hope for the future, even if that hope was rooted in the terror of the unknown.

Staring at the ceiling through sleepless nights, the question haunted me: *Why is this happening to me?*

According to the Old Testament, my arrogance and recklessness had summoned this retribution. But pain, regardless of its origin, has a purpose. It was only through this catastrophic fall that I was forced to genuinely examine my soul. The flip side of unimaginable cruelty is grace.

In that revelation, the two testaments finally merged for me: to reach the light, you must drag yourself through the absolute dark. You only truly find yourself in the crucible. I stopped asking, “*Why is this happening to me?*” and began asking, “*What is this for?*”

Still, I couldn't accept the New Testament's demand for total submission. If every hair that falls from my head is predestined by God, then free will is an illusion, and I am nothing but a puppet. But as I read the Psalms, I found passages that didn't demand weakness—they radiated power, charging me with fierce, defiant energy.

I studied the prayers closely, but they never fully resonated. They were written by ancient men facing their own unique tragedies. I realized I needed to forge my own prayer—one born from the concrete and blood of my current reality.

I turned to meditation. I needed to purge my mind of the crushing weight of captivity. I realized I had been living in a state of perpetual psychological weeping. My mind was consumed by suffering, judgment, anger, and a toxic thirst for revenge against the people who had wronged me.

Meditation forced me toward a state of radical acceptance. I realized that until I accepted the reality of my destruction, I would never find peace. As long as I agonized over my stolen business, my defrauded parents, the girl who walked away, and the friends who betrayed me, I *was* that suffering. But the moment I accepted that my old life was dead, that I was entirely alone with absolutely nothing left to my name, the noise stopped.

My mind cleared. I shifted my focus to the present moment, which allowed me to start gathering the internal resources required to survive the future. Moving from furious denial to calm acceptance was the turning point of my spiritual liberation.

Every day, I leaned harder into acceptance. Once I embraced the absolute depths of my isolation, I found immense power inside it. I was alone, but within that solitude, my mind was entirely free. I

realized that *hope* requires external validation from the world, but *faith* is generated internally; it requires no outside proof.

Faith in myself, in my own grit and intellect, became my bedrock. It armored me against the darkest moments and connected me to the Creator—a higher power I couldn't see or hear, but whose presence I felt vibrating in the silence of my cell. That clarity healed my soul and rebooted my nervous system.

But epiphanies are fragile. I knew that to survive the coming years, I had to hardwire this new philosophy into my daily habits.

First, I stopped talking and started listening. Silence is a form of active camouflage—it is action within stillness. In my past life, I talked too much, leaking valuable information and making myself vulnerable. Once I shut my mouth and truly listened, I became hyper-aware of the prison dynamics. I gathered far more intelligence by sitting in silence than I ever did by asking questions.

Second, I embraced radical flexibility. Before prison, I was notoriously stubborn; I always had to smash my way through obstacles. But a stone shatters when struck by a hammer. Water simply absorbs the blow and flows around the weapon. I realized I had to become water, not stone. Flexibility is born from acceptance. I had to accept the brutal reality of the prison ecosystem and fluidly adapt to it if I

wanted to survive.

This was my new toolkit. It was modest, but it was mine. Like a sapling, this new mindset needed time to take root. There were days when the old fears and the old rage tried to claw their way back to the surface. But every time I wavered, I reminded myself that if I let the wind of doubt snap this new foundation, I would die in this place.

6. HOW TIME FLOWS

Six months bled away—six months hovering on the razor's edge between life and death, with every day stretching out like a century. In those subterranean black sites, every hour was designed to stretch the human will until it snapped. But even standing on the absolute edge of the abyss, I knew one thing with absolute certainty: I wasn't broken. Battered, mutilated, and pushed to the absolute limit, yes—but my core remained intact. I had seen what a broken man looked like. I wasn't one of them.

On October 30, 2016, in Donetsk, I was formally sentenced to fourteen and a half years in a maximum-security penal colony for attempting to overthrow the constitutional order of the DNR and assassinate Alexander Zakharchenko. Normally, investigative proceedings take place in a standard pretrial detention facility. Mine had taken place strapped to an iron table in a basement.

After the gavel fell, the system moved with terrifying speed. I was given a chest X-ray and immediately transferred to a temporary holding facility. When I arrived, already bearing a

conviction, the guards were visibly confused; usually, inmates arrived there *before* their trials.

For the first time in half a year, I looked at guards who weren't wearing ski masks. For the first time, no one greeted me with a threat. It felt like I had been beamed onto another planet. Even though I was still a prisoner, a strange, forgotten sensation washed over me: calm. I was being treated like a human being.

I spent one day there before being moved to Detention Center No. 5. I spent five days in cell 1305, and then was marched down to the basement level, to cell 601. This block was different. It was reserved for political prisoners and men serving life sentences. Down there, time flowed at a different rhythm, giving each man the space to search his own soul.

Coming from the torture chambers, arriving in this cell felt almost absurd—like I had checked into a health resort. Here, you could actually speak. You were allowed to have an opinion. The guards didn't hide their faces. There were still strict rules, of course, but the atmosphere was no longer designed to physically crush you.

This new environment sparked a realization: even in the darkest, most oppressive conditions, humanity finds a way to endure. It reminded me that even inside a concrete box, they cannot take away your freedom of thought.

I shared the cell with two other men. Sasha was a separatist captain in the DNR who, for bizarre and murky reasons, was accused of working for Ukrainian intelligence. The other was Sanya Galagan, a Russian mercenary. After doing time in a prison in Rostov, Sanya came to the Donbas to fight for a paycheck. He ended up surrendering to Ukrainian forces and was recruited by their intelligence. He was arrested on his way to a mission in Donetsk after his girlfriend tipped off the authorities.

We were three men with incredibly tangled pasts, trapped together in a bizarre web of fate. Whether they were meant to be a lesson or a warning to me, I don't know. But our cell was a microcosm of the chaotic, fractured world outside. Even though both of my cellmates proudly supported the "Russian World," we managed to have calm, philosophical conversations. Prison operates on its own gravity; in a very real sense, we were all on the same side against the men holding the keys.

Our routine was incredibly rigid. At exactly 6:00 AM, the slot in the door opened and we were handed breakfast: a bowl of gray porridge with mysterious chunks of dark meat, or boiled cabbage. Dinner was a repeat of the same. We were also given tea and sugar. It was a meager diet, but watching how a man treats his food in a cage tells you everything you need to know about his

character.

But man does not live by bread alone. We didn't have a television, but we had books, and I used them to escape. With the help of one of my cellmates, I started learning English. He would dictate vocabulary words, and I would relentlessly drill them into my memory.

Once a day, they took us outside for an hour of exercise. It was the highlight of my existence. The yard had a pull-up bar and parallel bars—our own makeshift gym. That single hour was my window to the sky, my brief taste of freedom.

And then, there was the bathhouse.

Once a week, the political prisoners were granted a supreme luxury: an hour in a warm, quiet shower room where we could wash the grime off and briefly forget we were property of the state. It was a sanctuary for both body and soul.

But even in the bathhouse, the relentless laws of prison dynamics were in full effect. For the men kept in solitary confinement, the bathhouse was their only chance to hear human voices and catch news from the outside. The political prisoners were desperate for rumors of a prisoner exchange. A single whisper could send a man soaring with hope or crashing into despair. The bathhouse wasn't just a place to get clean; it was the nerve center of the prison.

In the cell next to mine was Zhenya Kononenko. He

was a political prisoner, a thoroughly decent man who became a true friend to me. Zhenya had passed intel on the separatists to Ukrainian security and was captured in 2015. While I was totally blacklisted from receiving care packages or visitors, Zhenya stepped in and saved me.

Because Zhenya was a local from Donetsk, his lawyers were active and he received regular care packages from his mother. He managed to smuggle a message out, connecting our parents. My mother began sending money to his mother, who bought the food and supplies I desperately needed and routed them through Zhenya's packages. Whenever a box arrived, Zhenya split it with me.

Those packages were a lifeline. A slice of real sausage or a clean shirt from the outside isn't just an item—it is a tangible manifestation of love. It is a physical reminder that someone out there is worried about you, that you are still connected to the human race.

However, prison also taught me a dark lesson about how easily morality evaporates in the face of survival. Hunger can turn a poet into a thief, and a philosopher into a beggar. Strip away a man's comfort, and the grand principles he swore by will collapse like a house of cards. It was shocking to see how cheaply human dignity could be bought.

Whenever word got out that I had received supplies through Zhenya, the letters started pouring in from

other cells. Some men wrote pathetic, sycophantic praises. Some begged, swearing they would die without a cigarette. Others offered to do absolutely anything I wanted for a single bite of a sandwich. I had to decide how to respond. I don't judge them—everyone survives the abyss in their own way, and everyone sets a different market price on their own honor. But those letters disturbed me. They forced me to realize how fragile a person's convictions really are.

A comfortable life smooths over the cracks in a person's character. Prison acts as a brutal stress test, forcing a man's truest instincts—fear, greed, ambition—to the surface. Some men hold their ground like titanium; others shatter. Some protect their dignity to the death; others trade it for a drag of tobacco. I realized that sometimes, the ultimate victory isn't escaping—it's simply maintaining your humanity in a house of madness.

Directly across the hall from us were the lifers. These men had committed unspeakable atrocities. One had systematically executed prisoners and a nurse; another, a former DNR colonel, had decided he possessed the divine right to play God with people's lives. They had crossed a line from which there is no redemption. But I didn't dare judge them. Their presence was a grim reminder of the razor-thin line separating a normal man from a monster.

In that prison, I was surrounded by men who had acquired absolute power during the chaos of the war, and let that power rot them from the inside out. I don't know if they were born sadists, or if the war made them that way. But the lesson was clear: power without a moral compass is a lethal weapon, and eventually, it destroys the man wielding it. The tyrants had ultimately found themselves locked in the same chains they used to bind others.

Looking into their eyes, I could see the ghosts of their victims. When they spoke, their voices carried the bitter, toxic weight of their ruined lives. It left me with dark, heavy thoughts. What sequence of choices transforms a human being into a butcher?

Sitting in that cell day after day, I reevaluated everything. The physical torment had ended, but the psychological introspection was just beginning. Cold, darkness, and hopelessness were my daily reality. Yet, alongside the despair, I discovered that a man can always mine an internal resource to keep fighting, no matter how crushing the pressure.

In that strange ecosystem, time didn't rush, but it didn't stand still either. In the slow, grinding current of weeks and months, every man in that block was fighting a silent war against an unjust fate. In every glance and every gesture, you could sense a feral hunger to return to the world of the living, and a desperate search for answers. Questions about meaning. About destiny. About

God.

7. FROM FEAR TO STRENGTH

The next phase of my nightmare began: transfer to Makiivka Penal Colony No. 32. It was a maximum-security camp with one of the most notorious reputations in the region. There was no running water; the pipes were only turned on for an hour in the morning and an hour in the evening. Inmates scrambled to fill plastic bottles just to flush the toilets or boil tea. The colony sat directly next to a heavy industrial plant that continuously spewed toxic, thick black smoke. Somedays, the smog was so dense you couldn't see a man standing ten meters away. This was my new home.

The guards herded the political prisoners together like cattle and shipped us to Makiivka. Both the administration and the general prison population were waiting for us.

Life in the colony operated on a completely different frequency. If solitary confinement was like a brutal monastery where a man lived deep inside his own head, Makiivka was a sprawling, vicious jungle. Surviving here meant learning, accepting, and navigating a labyrinth of complex criminal

underworld laws.

First came the strip search, then the shaved head, and finally, the psychological trap designed to break newcomers: the broom.

The broom is a test. The administration formally offers it to you. If you take it and sweep the floor, you are instantly branded a *kozel* (a "goat")—an inmate who actively collaborates with the administration. *Kozly* perform the colony's dirty work and are permanently outcast by the general prison population; a regular inmate won't even shake a goat's hand. However, selling your soul comes with perks: better living conditions and favors from the guards. The trap forces you to decide instantly if you are willing to trade your dignity for physical comfort.

Shortly after arriving, while out in the exercise yard, I ran into a ghost from my past life—a man named Yura. Back in the free world, Yura was a wrestler; we shared mutual friends and operated by similar principles. Sensing my disorientation in this new, dangerous ecosystem, he quietly took me under his wing, acting as a guide to the unwritten rules of the camp.



Winter at the colony. From the author's archive.

Yura was a heavy hitter in the prison; he had serious ties to the criminal hierarchy. I, however, was a highly radioactive political prisoner. Regular inmates were strictly forbidden from associating with us. If the administration had caught Yura talking to me, they would have punished the entire camp, tearing apart the delicate balance of order the inmates had built for themselves. But despite the massive risk to his reputation and safety, Yura didn't turn his back on me.

He taught me how to survive. The rules of Makiivka weren't dictated by the laws of the state, but by the ruthless, unwritten codes of honor, respect, and violence. Every day was a high-stakes test. I felt like

an explorer navigating a minefield without a map.

Because we were the new political arrivals, everyone was watching us. The administration acted like the Eye of Sauron, constantly probing our defenses, trying to figure out what drove us and where our breaking points lay. But the real game was being played with the other inmates. Every time a hardened convict locked eyes with you, he was silently asking: *Who are you, and where do you fit in our hierarchy?* Understanding your place on the food chain was a matter of life and death.

After surviving three months in the strict disciplinary block, the political prisoners were finally moved to our own barracks, situated between the second and third yard. Though the conditions were still incredibly bleak, our quality of life improved. We were given a two-story building with a private courtyard, where we built a makeshift pull-up bar. We could finally spend time outdoors, exercise, cook our own food, and establish a routine. The first floor had a small dining area, a bathroom, a shower, and a common room that, suspiciously, was always kept locked. The second floor was the sleeping quarters, which featured an unimaginable luxury: a small television.

On our very first day in the barracks, the camp's shot-caller—a man named Kvicha, who oversaw the entire criminal population—walked in to address us. His message was brief and ice-cold.

"We are right next door, but we won't be dealing with you directly," he stated. "Don't expect any help or favors from us. No smuggled phones. Nothing."

The message was clear: we were completely on our own. The administration wanted us totally quarantined from both the outside world and the general prison population to prevent contraband or intel from slipping through. Even our food was marched over directly from the kitchen by the guards.

There were fifteen political prisoners in our barracks, completely at the mercy of the block overseer—the head *kozel*—and his two lackeys. During an internal meeting, the guys elected me as the "senior man." I was now responsible for negotiating with both the administration and the criminal leaders. In the prison ecosystem, every clique needs a designated point-man to handle disputes. My athletic background, physical size, and refusal to break under pressure made me the obvious choice.

But my profile hadn't gone unnoticed by the administration, either. The first time they marched us to the bathhouse, I spotted a bulletin board hanging on the wall—a twisted "board of honor." It featured mugshots of the colony's most dangerous, non-compliant inmates. My photo was pinned right in the center. Beneath my face was a flattering list of my "accomplishments": prone to violence,

extreme flight risk, and, most dangerously, leadership qualities.

The block overseer and I clashed instantly. As the head *kozel*, he wielded dictatorial power over our daily lives. He dictated when we woke up, when we slept, when the TV was on, and who was allowed to speak to whom. But this specific *kozel* wasn't just doing his job; he was a sadistic tyrant who acted like a gulag warden.

He constantly tightened the screws for his own amusement. He would casually walk over and unplug the TV right in the middle of a program. He banned inmates from resting on their bunks during the day. He would force the entire barracks to stand outside in the freezing cold or scrub the yard for no reason. When he started verbally abusing the men—specifically targeting the weakest and oldest inmates—the atmosphere in the barracks became incredibly volatile.

The guys started coming to me, complaining that he was screaming at them and pushing them around. The breaking point came when the *kozel* threw a heavy ring of iron keys directly at the head of a visually impaired inmate with a bad leg.

If anyone dared talk back, the *kozel* threatened to throw them in "the pit"—the extreme isolation block reserved for severe violators, where the conditions were lethal. The older, frailer men were terrified of the pit. For the men who had already survived the

basement torture chambers, whose nervous systems were so shredded that a slamming door triggered a panic attack, the *kozol* 's reign of terror was unbearable.

I tried diplomacy. I talked to him almost daily, trying to de-escalate the tension. I explicitly warned him to back off. I told him that many of the men in this room had survived extreme torture, that they were operating on pure trauma, and that if he pushed them too far, he might go to sleep one night and never wake up. I tried to inject a healthy dose of fear into his brain, playing the mediator: *Everyone needs to calm down. The guys are stressed, you're stressed, let's just keep the peace.*

Honestly, I was exhausted. I didn't want to play peacekeeper, but I knew the political prisoners couldn't afford an open war. The criminal inmates told us that they kept their *kozly* in line through sheer violence—they beat them until they submitted. But if we, the politicals, tried a mutiny, the administration would use it as an excuse to massacre us.

So, I kept talking. And for a few days, it would work. He would apologize and back off. But inevitably, a few days later, his sadistic programming would reboot. He would find the weakest man in the room and try to break him. I realized the *kozol* was playing me—smiling to my face and terrorizing my men behind my back.

I was boiling over. On one hand, maintaining order was the only way to keep the guards out of our barracks. On the other hand, my fundamental duty as the senior man was to protect the guys who couldn't protect themselves.

Finally, my own discipline snapped. Ignoring all protocol, I flat-out refused to participate in the mandatory morning calisthenics. For this act of blatant insubordination, the administration slapped me with a formal reprimand and threw me in the pit for seven days.

With me out of the picture, the *kozol* crowned himself king. By the time I was released from the pit and walked back into the barracks, the air was practically sparking. An explosion was inevitable.

I had met a guy named Zhenya Chudnetsov—nicknamed "Chudik"—in the bathhouse. Chudik was a former fighter with the Azov battalion, and one of the most formidable, honorable men I have ever encountered. Because of his unit, the separatists had tortured him with medieval cruelty. He calmly told me how they had used pliers to rip his teeth out of his skull. Just hearing the story made my jaw ache.

But despite the unimaginable agony, Chudik never broke. He never gave up his brothers, and he never compromised his beliefs. His convictions were permanently inked onto his skin—a massive eagle bearing the Ukrainian coat of arms. The guards had

beaten him half to death specifically because of that tattoo.

To the rest of us, Chudik was the ultimate symbol of courage and iron willpower. But because he was a man of absolute principle, a collision with our tyrannical *kozel* was unavoidable. While I was trying to play the diplomat, Chudik came to me multiple times, his eyes dark with rage, telling me he was going to destroy the overseer. Every time, I talked him off the ledge.

Then came the spark.

Chudik and the *kozel* crossed paths on the narrow staircase. Instead of simply letting him pass, the *kozel* deliberately dropped his shoulder and violently checked Chudik into the wall.

Chudik came storming out into the yard where I was working out, practically vibrating with rage. I immediately intervened, trying to cool him down. We hit the pull-up bars together, burning off the adrenaline. Once he seemed calm, we headed back inside.

But as we crested the stairs to the second floor, the *kozel* was standing right there, screaming at another inmate. Chudik tried to squeeze past him in the narrow hall, but the *kozel* aggressively blocked his path.

It happened in a fraction of a second. Chudik stepped in and brutally headbutted him. The *kozel* dropped like a stone, and before he hit the floor,

Chudik had him locked in a professional chokehold.

I froze, watching the execution of a flawless grappling technique. And then, the room erupted.

This wasn't just a fight between two men. Chudik's headbutt acted as a detonator for months of repressed trauma, humiliation, and rage. It was as if a silent order had been broadcast across the barracks: *Kill him*. Old men and young men alike roared and swarmed the *kozel*. The inmates transformed from terrified, obedient rabbits into a pack of starving wolves.

That is what a revolution looks like. Its raw power is ignited by the violence of a few, but it feeds on the collective fury of the oppressed. Most men do not have the internal wiring to spark a rebellion on their own, but when a leader steps forward and strikes the first blow, the crowd will follow them into hell.

The fury in that room was driven by something primal—the desperate need to protect one's soul from utter degradation. As the battered *kozel* scrambled away, screaming into a phone for the guards to save his life, the illusion of the system shattered. We exposed the administration for what it was: a machine designed to turn men into soulless slaves.

Of course, every action carries a price. We paid in blood for our mutiny. Chudik, myself, and two others were dragged off to the pit, where the administration did everything in its power to break

our resolve. But sitting in that freezing darkness, we knew we had won. They couldn't touch our dignity.

Word of the uprising traveled faster than the guards. The story of the politicals who fought back spread far beyond the razor wire of our camp.

When they marched the four of us into the isolation block, a sound echoed through the concrete halls. The entire block was giving us a standing ovation. Murderers, thieves, and politicals alike stopped whatever they were doing to pound on the doors and applaud.

Our faces were bruised and bleeding, but our heads were held high. We had become a symbol of resistance. Our mutiny resonated in the deadened hearts of the men trapped in that colony. For one brief moment, the heavy, suffocating chains of the regime cracked, replaced by the electric crackle of solidarity.

That day was the turning point. It was the moment we finally cast off our fear and became a beacon of hope for the hopeless. We proved that it is always possible to fight back.

8. READING

Once I accepted the reality of my situation and found the strength to keep moving forward, I realized that a man must train not only his body, but his soul. While the methods for physical conditioning are well known, how exactly do you train your inner state? Finding the answer became an urgent necessity—a task I couldn't put off in a place where every minute could be my last. I decided to read as much as humanly possible.

There was a telling moment after I had spent a long stretch isolated in the Pit. A psychologist came down to evaluate my mental state. I told him I never felt lonely. "Today, Dostoevsky is with me. Tomorrow, Voltaire is stopping by. And in a couple of weeks, Nietzsche is dropping in for tea," I said. The psychologist looked at me, stunned. But I wanted him to understand a fundamental truth: I would never be in total isolation as long as I could still converse with books and pull answers from their pages.

Against all odds, I discovered that even prison walls couldn't shut the door to knowledge and self-development. This period of my life proved that

even surrounded by the cruelty and absolute injustice of the camp, you can find a path toward the light. I went looking for it in the words of great minds.

I had always loved reading. Initially, I gravitated toward sports psychology, and as I built my businesses, I shifted to marketing and management. But captivity fundamentally changed my relationship with books. It wasn't just about staving off loneliness. While my first week in the Pit was marked by a terrifying, crushing solitude, I eventually learned to turn inward, and even found peace in the silence. In books, I was hunting for answers to the questions tormenting me. I wanted to drill down to the core truth: how this world operates, how my own mind works, and where God fits into all of it.

When you are locked in a cage, finding time to read is easy. I devoured classic literature, philosophy, theology, and esotericism. More than a hundred volumes passed through my hands: Jack London, Voltaire, Dostoevsky, Tolstoy, Pushkin, Nietzsche, Dante, Plato, Lao Tzu. I drank them in the way a dying traveler drinks water. I finished *The Brothers Karamazov* in four days, and because I had always loved Dostoevsky, I ended up reading everything he ever wrote. I would juggle three books at once, switching between them. Reading became not just a refuge, but the foundation of my deep internal

reflection.

Because the prison had a library, a lot of inmates read. Surprisingly, spiritual and esoteric literature was in incredibly high demand, which gave me the chance to study nearly every major religion in the world. But I was most interested in psychology books that offered practical, actionable solutions. Technically, such books were banned in the prison, but somehow they still smuggled their way in from the outside, and I borrowed them from other inmates. These books kept a small flame of hope alive in my soul, reminding me of the boundless resilience of the human spirit.

One day, I got my hands on a book called *PEAT* by Zivorad Slavinski, and it triggered a genuine breakthrough. It wasn't just another volume on a shelf; it was a map pointing inward, offering concrete tools to process traumatic experiences. It didn't just tell a story or wax philosophical—it was a purely practical manual. By following its instructions, I learned how to convert negative emotions and traumatic memories into strength, taking the darkest moments of my captivity and refining them into pure energy.

These techniques became my shield against the crushing negativity of the prison environment. They taught me the art of self-regulation, helping me harmonize my inner world and heal the ruptures in my personal energy. I dove deeper into spiritual

practices, learning how to anchor myself in a state of calm and purge my psychological wounds.

But this path was just as grueling as the physical reality of the camp. These weren't books you could just read once and toss aside. They demanded practice, rigorous self-discipline, and genuine internal work. You had to dissect the text, apply it to yourself, and descend into the deepest, darkest chambers of your own subconscious. You had to walk straight toward your own terror and manually slaughter the demons living in your head in order to become whole. Not everyone has the stomach for that. But I decided I did.

Strangely enough, this grueling process of psychological cleansing pushed me toward art—I began writing poetry.

Even the purely philosophical texts gave me profound insights. In Carl Jung's *Psychology and Alchemy*, I read that the structure of the human personality, like every natural process, contains polarities. Every phenomenon is generated by the tension between these opposing forces. The conscious mind usually refuses to accept its own dual nature, even though this duality is the very source of all our energy.

The existence of opposites—of complementary polar forces—is a fundamental law of our universe, governing matter, energy, space, and time. In Western philosophy, Heraclitus was the first to

write that every entity is a reconciliation of opposites, that “all is one,” and that human experience is merely the interplay of these forces: sleep and waking, morality and immorality, life and death. Aristotle later argued these opposites were irreconcilable, a theory that peaked centuries later with René Descartes.

But science eventually proved this hard division was an illusion. In the twentieth century, quantum physics finally drilled down to the level of elementary particles. Physicists like Werner Heisenberg and David Bohm proved that the observer and the observed object form a single, unified whole. You cannot separate a person observing a phenomenon from the phenomenon itself.

But this truth existed long before quantum physics. We all know the ancient Taoist symbol of *Taijitu*—the circle dividing Yin and Yang. It perfectly illustrates the unity of opposites: positive, active energy flowing seamlessly into negative, passive energy. They exist simultaneously, completing each other. One of the earliest Chinese texts, the *I Ching*, teaches that when Yang reaches the absolute peak of its power, Yin energy is born deep inside it, just as night begins its approach at the exact moment of high noon. Darkness only exists because light exists. Stillness and motion only have meaning relative to one another. Every thing carries the seed of its own

destruction, and when that seed grows strong enough, the polarity flips.

According to Taoist teachings, to restore your inner unity, you must neutralize this dualism. You must rid yourself of polarities in your spiritual life. In true unity, the beginning and the end exist simultaneously. As a Zen master once put it: *“When I meditated, every bird and every cloud vanished from the clear sky. All that remained was me and the mountains. And then, even I disappeared.”*

Osho echoed this, teaching that nothing in the universe is unnecessary. Day is good, and night is equally good. You cannot choose one and ignore the other. To reject one side is to deprive yourself of half of your existence, and half a life is worthless. You must learn to see the beautiful harmony in the union of yes and no, of life and death.

This concept of reconciling polarities appears everywhere. In the Bible, Adam was created in the image of God as a complete human being; the later creation of woman symbolized a separation from that perfection—the birth of duality. Plato argued that marriage is merely a desperate attempt to restore the androgynous unity lost when humanity was split in two. The Tarot system, whose origins may stretch back to ancient Egypt, vividly illustrates this neutralization of opposites. The High Priestess card shows a woman wearing a crown with two horns (symbolizing duality) with a full moon resting

perfectly between them (symbolizing unity).

The great mystery of alchemy—the search for the philosopher's stone—is an archetype designed to heal the Christian fracture between good and evil. Alchemists believed that if opposing forces (body and soul, man and woman, active and passive) were sealed in an alchemical vessel and subjected to intense inner fire, they would eventually fuse and be "released." This implies that until they are integrated, these polarities hold the human soul hostage.

Jung saw the clear parallel here. Just as the alchemist transforms lead into gold, a human being must transform the chaotic, warring forces of their unconscious into the psychological equivalent of gold: a unified, indivisible personality. Through the spiritual fire of inner work, a person achieves wholeness. The boundary between polarities dissolves.

It turned out that this integration was exactly what I had been searching for.

The mystic G.I. Gurdjieff wrote that humans are made entirely of polarities. Look at how we perceive the world: every sensation, feeling, and thought is aggressively categorized as positive or negative, good or bad, pleasant or unpleasant. Whoever is victorious today will inevitably be defeated tomorrow. Anyone who observes their own mind will notice this frantic pendulum swing.

The spiritual teacher Meher Baba expanded on this. Over a lifetime, a person swings endlessly between success and failure, wealth and poverty, strength and helplessness, dominance and submission. These swings happen on autopilot. We are tossed back and forth, entirely at the mercy of our circumstances. The whole world is a battlefield of polarities. A wave pulls back from the shore only to violently crash forward again; we exhale only so we can inhale; we burn down the old to build the new.

The problem is, as long as you are trapped in this pendulum swing, inner balance is impossible. Our desperate attempts to cling only to the "good" feelings are doomed. Accepting this requires profound wisdom. A man wants to live and violently pushes away the concept of death, refusing to accept they are two sides of the same coin. When he builds something, he refuses to acknowledge that one day it will turn to dust. The ultimate goal of spiritual evolution is to break free from this frantic oscillation and find balance in the eye of the storm.

To achieve that, you must annihilate fear. True unity means there is no division. People cling to their rigid definitions of "good" and "bad" because they are terrified of what lies on the other side of the fence. But as a wise man once said, even in the most beautiful paintings, we see not only the light, but the shadows that give it shape.

The process of recognizing your own polarities

begins with understanding that almost everything you do is automatic. You must draw a hard line between what you do unconsciously, and what you do with true intention. You have to hunt down your internal contradictions and neutralize them. Once you integrate your primary polarities, you begin to understand the sick games life plays with you. You finally break free from your robotic programming. You earn true freedom of choice.

Once balanced between the positive and negative fields, your consciousness acts as a massive gyroscopic stabilizer. You stand firmly in the center. You stop identifying with one extreme and stop resisting the other. The brutal drama of life continues to rage around you, but you become the silent observer watching the stage. You rise above the chaos.

Jung noted that the East discovered this "middle path" because ancient Chinese philosophers never tried to forcibly amputate the dark side of human nature from the light. For them, "yes" and "no" remained intimately connected, which allowed them to develop a vastly superior, all-encompassing state of consciousness.

I don't know how long it took the ancient monks to neutralize their polarities, but sitting in my cell, I got to work. I realized that my past trauma was dictating my present actions. To rewrite my source code and break free of my robotic reactions, I had

to hunt down every single internal contradiction and integrate it.

I realized that from early childhood, we are infected with habits, rules, and judgments that run our lives like an automated operating system. Everything we "know" about the world—how to relate to money, whether God exists, what success looks like—is hardwired into our brains before the age of seven, before we even possess critical thinking.

When I began dissecting my polarities, I realized I had never actually been free. I had lived exactly how my parents and grandparents programmed me to live. But their programming was based on their own subjective, often flawed experiences. Because my parents never achieved absolute happiness or peace, the principles they installed in me ultimately made me unhappy, too.

Most people refuse to believe they are running on automatic programming. They think they are the architects of their own lives. In reality, they are merely echoing their parents' fears and making their parents' choices. That is why generational trauma is so cyclical: poverty breeds poverty, divorce breeds divorce, misery breeds misery. People follow a map drawn by someone else.

But you can destroy the programming. You can rip out the old wiring and take absolute control of your life.

Using the tools left by the sages, I dove into my own

abyss. I confronted the dark, twisted fragments of myself that had taken root during the torture. Down in that basement, I had lived in a state of pure, animalistic terror. I had to process every single one of those agonizing sensations. Through focused inner work, I integrated fear into victory. I integrated hatred into confidence. I integrated blinding anger into deep kindness.

One practice required me to mentally return to the torture chamber and face the men who had mutilated me. Inside my mind, I found the shattered, terrified version of myself that was still trapped on that iron table, begging for mercy. I dragged those buried memories into the light, relived the agony, and fully accepted the part of me that had been broken.

Once I fully accepted my reality—every brutal rise and devastating fall of my life—the burden vanished. An explosive reserve of positive energy was unlocked inside my chest. It felt as if I had been carrying a hundred-pound rucksack my entire life, and someone had finally cut the straps. Acceptance became my ultimate weapon. By accepting circumstances that seemed utterly hopeless, the panic faded, and I began to see new solutions. It turned out there was no such thing as a dead end. In that total liberation, I found my balance.

9. THE BEGINNING OF LEADERSHIP

Our mutiny against the block overseer did not go unpunished. After the fight, Chudik, two other inmates, and I were dragged off to the Pit for two weeks. But the punishment was worth it; it cleared the suffocating, toxic air in our barracks.

The administration replaced the tyrannical *kozel* with a man named Merik. Merik was cut from entirely different cloth—he was reasonable, honest, and actually tried to maintain a sense of fairness within the warped camp system. With him in charge, we quickly stabilized the barracks and organized our daily routine so that we could live in relative peace.

Whenever fresh transports arrived—bringing captured soldiers, athletes, and political prisoners—I pulled them aside and briefed them on the rules of our barracks and the reality of the Pit. My primary message was simple: *Do not be afraid*. Even in this hellhole, you can maintain your dignity, but only if we stick together and defend our rights.

United, we were a fortress. But if the administration managed to divide us or remove the leaders, the men would instantly revert to a compliant, easily manipulated herd.

The penal system leaves very few avenues for justice. Often, the only viable option is uncompromising resistance. On that path, you need heroes—men willing to sacrifice their own flesh for the common good, men who aren't afraid to bleed for the right to remain human. Those men become lighthouses for everyone else in the dark. After the uprising, Chudik and I inadvertently became those leaders. With that status came genuine authority and recognition across the prison hierarchy.

To survive in a maximum-security camp, you must be infinitely resourceful and willing to negotiate. I decided to build bridges with the widest possible range of people—from the administration guards to the heavy-hitting criminal bosses.

All my reading severely sharpened my emotional intelligence. Whenever I read Leo Tolstoy, I was staggered by his ability to X-ray the human soul and expose the deepest layers of his characters' inner worlds. I started applying that same X-ray vision to the men around me, noticing micro-expressions I would have missed in my past life.

A blank stare that others might dismiss as shallow suddenly became highly readable to me. In the dead, guarded eyes of the inmates, I began to spot

flashes of genuine emotion—everything from crushing sorrow to tiny sparks of joy. It was like reading an invisible book; I could look past their masks of aggressive indifference and see their hidden terrors and desperate hopes. This psychological insight gave me the skeleton key to connecting with anyone.

Using diplomacy and leverage, I engineered living conditions for myself that were unthinkable for a standard prisoner. I actually built a covert gym in our courtyard. I had a barbell loaded with up to a hundred kilograms, and a massive 36-kilogram sledgehammer that I used to strike an old rubber tire—a brutal way to build explosive power. The deafening *crack* of the hammer hitting the tire echoed across the entire camp. But every time an officer came sprinting into our sector to find the source of the noise, the equipment had already been perfectly dismantled and hidden. They never caught us.

But my absolute masterpiece of prison diplomacy was the contraband. We had five smuggled cell phones operating inside our barracks. In a world where a connection to the outside is worth its weight in gold, we were billionaires.

The administration was obsessed with keeping the political prisoners completely isolated. Cutting our communication was the cornerstone of their control, ensuring we couldn't access intel,

coordinate support, or leak the reality of the camp to the public. But I shattered their blockade.

Through my network, I not only secured phones, but high-speed internet access. I stayed informed, communicated with my loved ones, and even quietly influenced the narrative outside the razor wire.

To the administration, those phones were an act of high treason. To me, they were the ultimate expression of rebellion. It was a daily reminder that I refused to surrender my rights, no matter how much concrete they poured over me.

In the brutal vacuum of the camp, where human solidarity is designed to erode, I made it my mission to forge a genuine brotherhood. That is how we established our *obshchak* —the communal prisoner fund. It wasn't just a stash of goods; it was the ultimate symbol of mutual respect and survival. Men started voluntarily surrendering a portion of their meager rations and supplies for the good of the collective. For some, it was a way to share their wealth; for others, a way to repay a favor. Contributing to the *obshchak* meant you belonged to the pack.

In the soul-crushing monotony of the camp, a single cookie or a cup of hot, sweetened tea funded by the *obshchak* could pull a man out of severe depression. These tiny gestures of brotherhood gave men the strength to keep fighting for their

sanity.

Deep within those walls, where time felt like a stagnant swamp, I relentlessly trained my mind. My psychological practices became my weapon against the encroaching darkness. By systematically purging my fears and phobias, my internal energy spiked. I began to view the ecosystem of the prison from a completely different altitude.

The armed men in uniform, whom I had once viewed with sheer terror, were demystified. I realized that beneath the camouflage and the body armor, they were just exhausted, flawed men with their own anxieties, mortgages, and illnesses.

This realization completely changed the power dynamic. I stopped talking to the administration like they were my executioners, and started treating them like potential assets. Many of the guards essentially became my informants, leaking the inner workings of the system and giving me the leverage to manipulate the colony from the inside out.

Watching the prisoners and the guards, I constantly asked myself: *Why is he doing this?* The answer was usually brutally simple: fear, desperation, or greed. I realized that under the right pressure, any man is capable of atrocities. I was constantly walking a razor-thin line between preserving my own moral compass and doing whatever it took to survive the meat grinder.

Sometimes, I had to act with ruthless hardness. It

wasn't cruelty; it was a necessary defense mechanism to protect myself and my men. Balancing my humanity with the cold, hard pragmatism required to survive the camp was the most difficult tightrope I ever walked.

Prison was a relentless gauntlet of trials. I made mistakes, and the camp made sure the lessons were incredibly painful. But every failure was a stepping stone. Every beating made my armor thicker. I learned to forgive myself for my miscalculations, extract the intel, and adjust my strategy. The camp became a black mirror reflecting my greatest strengths and my deepest flaws. I realized that getting back up off the concrete is what makes a man truly alive.

My internal evolution turned me into something more than just a resilient prisoner—it turned me into a leader. Watching how I handled the administration and maintained my stoic balance, the other men began coming to me for counsel when the darkness got too heavy. By default, I became the resident therapist of the barracks.

My first real psychological intervention was with Dima. He was a deserter, profoundly traumatized by the military machine. He had volunteered for the airborne troops in 2014, but clashed violently with his commanding officer. The commander systematically degraded him, threatening to kill him and let his body rot in a trench. Dima finally

snapped under the psychological torture. He went on leave, fled to Moscow, and was subsequently hunted down by the FSB, extradited to the DNR, and sentenced to fifteen years for terrorism.

His soul was shattered by the betrayal. The entire camp thought Dima was a lost cause. He lived in a state of severe suicidal ideation, frequently threatening to kill himself after phone calls with his family. He was completely checked out.

But I saw the raw potential underneath his trauma. One day, I walked up to him and asked, "Do you want me to help you?"

He looked at me with dead eyes and whispered, "Yes."

I asked him to identify the core of his agony. It was the white-hot, consuming hatred he harbored for the commander who had destroyed his life.

I guided him through his first psychological practice. When he finally opened his eyes, he looked physically stunned. He said the suffocating anger was completely gone—bizarrely, he felt like he could embrace the man who ruined him. We kept working, unpacking the trauma and reprogramming how he viewed his past. Dima transformed. His posture straightened, the deadness left his eyes, and his soul began to heal.

It was a staggering victory. I knew the techniques worked because they had saved my own life, but successfully operating on another man's mind was a

revelation. It proved that deep psychological intervention could literally pull a man back from the edge of the abyss. I neutralized his suicidal impulse in exactly thirty minutes.

That experience proved that psychological work isn't academic theory—it is a scalpel that can save a life. But the patient has to willingly walk into the operating room. Because processing deep, generational trauma is excruciating, the choice to heal must be absolute. I realized that wielding this knowledge required immense responsibility and a delicate touch.

Then there was Vova Burtsev. Vova was a chaotic, tangled mess of a human being. Years of hard time had hollowed out his face, and his eyes burned with erratic, violent energy. He had a hair-trigger temper and was constantly getting dragged into violent altercations. Most of the guys avoided him, treating him like an unexploded bomb.

But beneath his abrasive, cruel jokes, I sensed a massive, festering wound. His aggression was a crude shield against his own internal demons. I pulled him aside for a private conversation. It wasn't easy, but he eventually dropped the tough-guy act. I saw a deeply damaged man who had been chewed up by the system and had completely lost his faith in humanity. Yet, despite his explosive flaws, Vova desperately wanted to change.

He wanted a clean slate so badly that he even

offered to sign over the deed to his apartment on the outside as collateral for his good behavior. I knew real change doesn't work like that—it has to come from within—but I was willing to bet on him. I believe any man can change if he has the right structural support.

Everyone stumbles. The goal isn't to avoid mistakes, but to extract the lesson and keep marching. But giving a man a second chance is a heavy burden. Sometimes, true support doesn't look like a pat on the back; it looks like brutal strictness, rigid boundaries, and severe consequences. Helping a man rebuild his moral compass requires tough love that looks incredibly harsh to an outsider.

Seeing Vova's desire to change, another inmate in our barracks, Serega, stepped up and officially vouched for him. In the criminal underworld, vouching is a blood oath. You are guaranteeing a man's behavior, and if he fails, you inherit his debts and his punishment. Serega didn't fully comprehend the gravity of the contract he had just signed.

Predictably, Vova couldn't control his demons and broke his word. Because Serega had vouched for him, Serega had to pay the price. To enforce the rules of the contract, I made Serega sit in the center of the room, and I shaved his head into a bald, humiliating "Lenin haircut" in front of the entire barracks.

I didn't do it to be cruel. I did it to ensure every man

in that room understood that trust in prison is a matter of life and death. Your word is your bond. If you co-sign for a man's character, you must be ready to suffer the consequences of his failure. Serega only wore the haircut for half a day before shaving the rest of his head bald, but the lesson was permanently etched into his brain.

True leadership in a maximum-security camp requires clinical insight and ruthless decisiveness. Men operating under the influence of severe trauma and despair will act like cornered animals. My job wasn't just to manage them; it was to protect them, correct them, and occasionally make highly unpopular, authoritarian decisions to keep the wolves from our door.

Meanwhile, I was constantly navigating the crosshairs of the camp administration. I was receiving daily threats from the leadership. I had to ensure my own physical survival, while simultaneously acting as the shield for the men who relied on me. It was an exhausting, high-wire balancing act that required absolute hyper-vigilance. But I knew that diamonds are forged under this exact kind of crushing pressure.

Eventually, I pushed the administration too far, and they threw me back into the Pit. This stint would turn out to be my longest yet.

Sometime after the heavy iron door slammed shut, I received word from the barracks. Without my daily

intervention, the men I had left behind had folded. They completely submitted to the administration, surrendered their smuggled phones, and quietly resigned themselves to whatever scraps the guards threw at them. Without a leader, the fire went out.

10. “THE PIT”

The Pit was a grim, single-story concrete block. A central corridor ran down the middle, flanked by about ten heavy iron doors on each side. This was the maximum-punishment block, designed to break anyone who refused to bow to the administration's regime. Some men were sent there for legitimate infractions; others were thrown in simply for defying the sadistic whims of a barracks *kozel* . As a rule, any leader who stood up for the inmates' rights was systematically dragged back to the Pit until he surrendered.

The regime in the Pit was draconian. Wake-up was at 5:00 AM. Immediately after, the guards entered, rolled up your thin mattress, and confiscated it. The bunk bed was hoisted up against the wall and locked in place with heavy chains. During the day, you were strictly forbidden from sitting or lying down on the floor. You could stand, pace the few feet of your cell, or perch uncomfortably on a narrow wooden stool bolted to a tiny table. You stayed like that until lights-out at 9:00 PM.

No personal belongings were allowed. The cell was

freezing. Care packages and phone calls were absolutely banned. And worst of all was the food ration: a crust of bread, a scoop of sour cabbage, and a tin cup of weak tea for breakfast. Dinner was exactly the same.

During my final stint in the Pit, I was locked in there for over a year. Every single day was a brutal war of attrition against my body and mind. I watched men literally lose their sanity in those cells. But I stubbornly held onto the belief that one day, the nightmare would end, and I would walk out free.

During the initial, most agonizing phase of my confinement, I shared the cell with Serega Usatyuk, a guy with sharp features and a dead-steady gaze. Having him there meant I wasn't fighting the silence alone. We shared our rations, traded philosophies, and mapped out fantasies of our future freedom. His presence made the concrete box slightly more bearable.

But eventually, Serega broke. He couldn't handle the sensory deprivation and threatened to kill himself if they didn't take him out. The guards transferred him back to the main barracks, leaving me entirely alone. From then on, I had nothing to rely on but the architecture of my own mind.

That first week of total solitary confinement was a severe test. Despair wrapped around my chest, tightening like a vise with every passing hour. My single allotted hour in the caged exercise yard

became my only salvation—at least out there, I had the company of the guard's shadow. But even the yard time was structured to humiliate me.

The administration had permanently flagged me as a high-value threat: extreme flight risk, prone to assault, likely to incite a riot, and highly capable of bribing the staff. Because of this, my restrictions were much tighter than those of the other men in the Pit. While the rest of the block went to the yard together at 6:00 AM, I was kept locked in my cell. I was walked out later, completely alone, ensuring I never made visual contact with another human being.

Communicating with me was highly radioactive. If a prisoner was caught trying to pass me a message, his phone privileges were instantly revoked. The warden explicitly told the entire block that if I was ever caught with a phone, the *entire camp* would lose their communication rights. That was the weight of my reputation as "Terrorist Number One." The Pit was designed to isolate me not just from the free world, but from the prison itself.

But concrete is porous, and eventually, the isolation cracked. The political prisoners were too terrified to approach me, but the hardened criminal inmates began making cautious, calculated contact through the walls. Eventually, a heavy hitter agreed to smuggle a phone to me. But he gave me an absolute ultimatum: *You can never be caught with it.* If a raid

happened, I had to swallow it, smash it to pieces, or flush it—whatever it took. If the guards confiscated an intact phone from me, the entire Pit would face collective punishment. My absolute commitment to never betraying that trust became my highest law.

Securing that phone was a massive tactical victory. It was my lifeline to reality. The time I had spent in total solitary had shown me how quickly a man's mind rots in the dark. That tiny screen gave me hope and kept my intellect sharp.

I pried up a loose floorboard in my cell and carved out a hidden compartment for the device. Knowing I was the highest-priority target in the block, I developed an elaborate protocol for retrieving and hiding it. The guards and the intelligence officers *knew* I had a phone—they just couldn't prove it. Their relentless, unannounced raids turned into a high-stakes game of cat and mouse. But my absolute refusal to let the other inmates down kept me one step ahead of the search squads.

One day, an officer and a sergeant burst into my cell and marched straight toward the loose floorboard, as if they had a treasure map. I had sensed a raid was coming, so I had actually moved the phone to a different stash inside my nightstand. When the guards ripped up the floorboard and found the hole empty, they paused in confusion. I knew I had a three-second window to save the entire block from collective punishment.

I dove for the nightstand, grabbed the phone, and sprinted through the open cell door into the main corridor. As I bolted down the hall, scanning frantically for an out, I noticed the heavy iron "food flap"—the chuckhole used to pass trays into the cells—was hanging open on a neighboring door. Without breaking stride, I whipped the phone through the slot into the neighbor's cell and kept running as if I was just trying to stretch my legs.

By the time the furious officer screamed at me to halt and assume the search position against the wall, I was completely clean.

The phone was safe, and the only people who knew where it landed were the inmates locked inside that cell. After the raid blew over and the guards left, the neighbors quietly passed it back to me.

In my cell, the officer had screamed at the sergeant in blind rage. All they found in my floorboard was a useless charging cable. The inmates who had witnessed my sleight-of-hand couldn't contain themselves—some laughed, others applauded. It was a flawless execution.

That specific incident cemented my legend in the Pit. I had protected the phone, secured our lifeline, and shielded the men who took the risk to supply it. The criminal inmates deeply respected that level of loyalty. That day, the entire block realized I was a man who lived by the code.

Following the raid, a new warning was added to my

profile on the administration's "board of honor": *Highly capable of recruiting colony staff*. The administration realized that a phone could only breach the Pit if a guard was compromised. They assumed I had bought one of their own men, which meant I required even heavier surveillance.

I quickly learned that the Pit operated by its own bizarre set of underworld laws, totally distinct from the main camp. In the dead of night, inmates used highly sophisticated, handmade skeleton keys to quietly pop the locks on their cell doors. They would slip out into the corridor just to stretch their legs, breathe the cold air, and look out the grated windows at the stars. Because my reputation as an honorable inmate was now rock-solid, my door was popped at night, too. I was invited to join the ghosts in the hallway.

The Pit housed the most stubborn, defiant men in the system: inmates who refused to confess, high-ranking mafia bosses (*vory v zakone*), and highly colorful underworld figures. Because of this volatile mix, the atmosphere was wildly unpredictable. Sometimes the administration would crack down with iron fists; other times, they completely backed off. At the peak of my influence, I was so highly respected that one of the main barracks actually began cooking specialized meals and smuggling them down to my cell.

My status grew even further when I tapped into the

prison's underground economy. In the Pit, I was constantly analyzing the psychology of the other inmates. That is how I met Alexei—an absolute virtuoso with a deck of cards, a man who treated the con as an art form.

Alexei ran a fast, high-stakes Russian card game called *trinka*. He would intentionally deal incredibly strong hands to every player at the table, whipping the men into a betting frenzy. One guy would hold 30 points, another 28, another 29. Convinced they had the winning hand, the men would relentlessly raise the stakes. But when the cards flipped, Alexei always miraculously held three sevens—the ultimate hand, which he called "the million." I watched hardened criminals lose everything they owned in the time it takes to smoke a cigarette, spiraling into massive debt and begging for mercy.

I sat down and played Alexei exactly once. One round was enough to realize I was swimming with a shark. In Alexei's hands, the deck was a weapon of mass destruction.

But Alexei taught me a vital lesson: the ultimate currency in the Pit was marijuana, or as it was called on the inside, "the high." You could buy a man's soul with it. Even the administration guards frequently smoked it to cope with the bleak reality of their jobs. Through a network of outside contacts, Alexei smuggled bulk shipments of marijuana into the Pit. It fueled the card games,

numbed the psychological agony of solitary, and acted as cash to purchase food, tobacco, phones, and the guards' silence.

Once I understood the mechanics of the shadow economy, I aggressively leveraged it. I successfully recruited a sergeant who pulled shifts in the Pit every three days. I paid him to smuggle in my own supply of marijuana, which I then weaponized as currency to buy absolute freedom within the isolation block. By controlling the supply lines, I rapidly expanded my influence until I was pulling strings that affected the entire penal colony.

The camp wardens were fully aware that I was running the Pit, but they were paralyzed. The lower-ranking guards were all sitting in my pocket. I had architected a flawless survival strategy based on bribery, psychological manipulation, and absolute control.

The Pit is not just a concrete punishment box; it is the ultimate crucible of the human spirit. Every day is a silent, violent war. You aren't fighting the guards; you are fighting your own suffocating fears and doubts. In the Pit, a man is judged entirely by the strength of his convictions, and how much blood he is willing to spill to defend them.

When I was first thrown into total isolation, I teetered on the edge of a catastrophic psychological break. Stripped of human contact and left to rot in the silence, my mind spiraled into

chaos. How do you anchor yourself when gravity disappears? I felt like I was drowning in the darkest trenches of my own soul. But as the brutal days bled into months, I learned to tame the chaos.

Naked, freezing, and utterly alone, I forced myself to be reborn. I evolved into the undisputed master of that concrete tomb. The power I wielded wasn't just criminal status; it was the physical manifestation of my victory over my own terror. I learned the ultimate truth of survival: there is no victory without devastating defeat. The only thing that matters is standing back up.

When I finally stood up, I was harder and more lethal than I had ever been. Men who had previously tried to break me were now quietly asking for my protection. Inmates in the main camp would deliberately assault guards just to get thrown into the Pit so they could access my phones and hear their wives' voices.

I embraced my role as the guardian of the Pit. After surviving over a year in the hole, I had practically become part of the architecture—a resident spirit welcoming the damned. We established a strict protocol: every new arrival had to stand at his door, state his name, and announce his sentence to the block. Most men broke after a week; some lasted a month. I outlasted them all.

Makiivka Colony No. 32 was the final destination for captured soldiers and political prisoners. But before

they entered the general population, they had to survive a mandatory quarantine in the Pit. I became their drill instructor. I would walk to their cell doors, hand them a phone to call their families, and deprogram their terror. I explained the exact mechanics of the colony, taught them how to navigate extortion, and most importantly, reminded them that the regime in the barracks was not invincible. The guards wrote the rules, but the inmates controlled the reality.

I became the historian of the resistance. I told them exactly how we had brutally overthrown the *kozel* and seized control of our barracks. I didn't hide the fact that we paid a horrific price in blood and punishment, but I made sure they understood it was worth it. I told them about the men who had proudly marched into the Pit for their beliefs, wearing their punishment like a medal of honor.

Watching me operate with absolute impunity, the criminal underworld changed their stance on the political prisoners and captured soldiers. We were no longer easy prey. We were granted communication rights; our voices mattered at the negotiating tables, and our dignity was strictly respected. Because I held the line, the systematic humiliation of men with political convictions came to a dead halt.

In the Pit, I witnessed the awe-inspiring power of absolute solidarity. We had a fragile, unspoken

truce with the administration regarding our single communal cell phone. But one day, a rogue shift supervisor decided to play hero, stormed a cell, and tried to confiscate the phone by force. The inmate didn't just refuse to hand it over—in a massive display of disrespect, he physically overpowered the officer and took the *guard's* personal cell phone as a trophy.

The Pit instantly went to red alert.

By the time the riot squad arrived to charge the inmate with assaulting a law enforcement officer, the tension was explosive. The warden stood in the corridor and threatened to bury the man with fresh charges. In perfect unison, every single inmate in the Pit kicked their doors, produced hidden razor blades, and screamed that they would slash their own throats and paint the concrete walls with blood if the guards touched him.

The image of those men, armed with razors and perfectly willing to die for the man in the cell next to them, shook me to my core. It was the ultimate display of collective defiance. Faced with a mass bloodbath, the administration blinked. The warden backed down, and a truce was negotiated to de-escalate the standoff.

But as the adrenaline faded, a dark realization settled over me. The men I had left behind in the relatively comfortable main barracks had instantly surrendered their dignity for extra rations. But the

hardened outcasts in the freezing Pit were ready to bleed out on the floor for a matter of principle.

Of course, the context mattered. The politicals in the barracks had survived unimaginable basement torture; their nervous systems were permanently wired to fear men in uniform. Every man has a breaking point. Only a very rare breed of man possesses the internal wiring to continuously fight back against impossible odds, and sadly, they are almost always in the minority.

11. THE HEALER'S PATH

I had been exposed to esoteric practices since childhood. My grandmothers used to drive out fear and heal the body and soul using nothing but words, reciting ancient incantations. I vividly remember a time when they pressed an apple against my warts, whispered a formula over it, and then buried the fruit in the ground. Just as the apple rotted away, my warts vanished.

When a lipoma formed on my neck during my long stretch in isolation, when my vision blurred and a constant ringing filled my ears, I knew this required a specific approach. These weren't simply physical ailments; they were somatic manifestations—the physical imprint of the deep psychological trauma I had endured, now rising to the surface in the silence of solitary confinement.

In those early days, before I managed to find my footing, my soul was caught in a violent storm. I was drowning in heavy memories, self-loathing, burning hatred, boiling rage, and a terrifying urge toward self-destruction. These agonizing emotions didn't just stay in my head; they drained my physical body.

I felt perpetually exhausted, and at night, nightmares hunted me down.

In isolation, I realized with absolute clarity that true balance only comes from harmony between body and spirit. Initially, I looked for salvation in physical training. In a place where every day was indistinguishable from the last, I began to exercise fiercely. I could feel my will to live growing stronger with every squat and every pull-up. Athletics became my shield against the abyss of despair. Taking freezing cold showers tested not just my body, but my mental fortitude—they shocked my system awake and reminded me of my own resilience. Every single day, no matter how hard it was, I conditioned both my flesh and my mind, ensuring they were unshakable in the face of whatever fate threw at me next.

But physical training alone wasn't enough. I realized the absolute necessity of doing continuous, internal psychological work.

When a person finds themselves in a crisis—when they hit rock bottom, when their life plans collapse, when they are thrust into a shocking reality—the first and most vital step is absolute acceptance. That process is excruciating, but it is the single most important tool for recovering from trauma. Acceptance allows you to release everything that has happened and land firmly in the present moment, free from the anchor of the past and the

crippling anxiety of the future.

Failing to accept your reality means destroying yourself a little more every single day. It means bleeding your internal resources dry and allowing the memory of your trauma to dictate your life. Once you accept it, you are free. A new life becomes possible. Even if that life is objectively terrible—as mine was, locked in a cage—you can still extract meaning from it. You can reboot your system and build something new. The suffocating weight of the past, just like the desperate waiting for a better future, will annihilate a person. You must accept everything as a lesson and mine every moment for fuel.

But how do you actually do that? To accept the past, you have to neutralize the emotional charge it carries. A person cannot accept a defeat as long as they are still consumed by anger or a thirst for revenge. I developed my own technique for breaking out of this state: I would mentally return to the exact moment of the traumatic event and force myself to relive it. I would allow myself to fully release whatever visceral reactions were trapped inside me, effectively closing the psychological loop. I repeated this over and over. With each repetition, the emotional charge shrank. Once the emotion is fully drained, acceptance naturally follows. Then, there is calm.

After I managed to process my own trauma this

way, other inmates noticed the change in my demeanor and started coming to me for help. Gradually, I developed the sequence of steps that would later become the foundation of my clinical practice in the free world.

The work always begins the same way: searching for the root cause. A problem only exists inside a person's mind; you just have to track it to its source. At its core, any trauma is a splintering of the identity—a separation from your own center, a profound sense of defeat. That is why you must descend into that defeat and uncover *why* the person made the internal decision to surrender. Trauma always calcifies at the exact moment a person subconsciously decides they have been beaten, that they are unworthy, or that they have been permanently humiliated.

You cannot simply talk your way out of that state. Intellectual reframing doesn't work here. The only option is to relive the event, allow your mind to execute the defense mechanisms you *wanted* to use at the time, and resurrect the hero inside yourself. Because only a hero—a victor—can accept a situation; a victim cannot. Once the event has been fully processed and stripped of its emotional venom, a person can move forward. They no longer carry a hidden trigger that can be tripped by a stray word. But this can only be achieved by mentally traveling back to the epicenter of the trauma and

releasing the trapped energy.

I always start by talking with a person to identify their dominant pain. Anxiety, aggression, the thirst for revenge, self-doubt—these are all symptoms of a defeat buried deep in the psyche. That defeat occurred during a specific past event, one the person may not even consciously remember.

It's fascinating. People endure horrific adult traumas—car crashes, combat, extreme physical and psychological violence—but in my work, we almost always end up tracing the root back to their childhood. The adult trauma triggered the collapse, but the foundational crack was formed years earlier. Often, people are stunned to realize that during their adult trauma, their subconscious was actually flashing back to a childhood wound. Sometimes, the original event happened so early that the conscious mind has no memory of it, but the nervous system remembers the emotion.

Defeat, the splintering of identity, the rejection of a part of oneself—these are shoved deep into the subconscious. From there, a person can burn massive amounts of internal energy for the rest of their life just trying to keep that foundational pain locked away. They live in a state of perpetual exhaustion. That pain is like a bathtub with a massive hole in it; no matter how much water you pour in, it will never be full. That is why I use emotion as the doorway to find the real problem.

Much later, I formally studied classical hypnotherapy, which allows a person to access memories their conscious mind has buried. When a human is born, they possess zero data about the world. Every belief and rule is downloaded into us over time, eventually becoming our automatic programming. If nothing catastrophic happens, many people run on this automatic software their entire lives. But often, the installation of these foundational beliefs—especially regarding religion or inherited worldviews—creates internal fractures. A person begins to feel a profound mismatch, a constant draining of energy, as their life quietly falls apart.

Hypnotherapy helps by bypassing the conscious mind to locate the original moment of defeat. Our sensory system—our eyes, ears, and nerves—records everything. To retrieve that corrupted data, you have to enter through the portal of emotion.

The body and spirit are one. Every psychological illness we carry eventually manifests in the physical body. Shock, trauma, and a lack of support are the primary architects of disease. Every man who has survived captivity carries a unique story, but they all share the experience of extreme violence against their body and mind. Their trauma doesn't just stem from the physical beatings; it comes from the excruciating waiting, the terror of the unknown,

and the psychological destruction of having their future dictated to them. That level of fear completely annihilates a person's individuality. They are trampled into the dirt.

How do you survive that? If your principles refuse to let you submit, your only option is to endure. That is why survivors carry such deep trauma. The psychological software is corrupted, and as a result, the physical hardware—the bodily tissue itself—begins to break down.

By addressing the trapped emotion, you can heal almost any deep-seated problem, including physical ailments. Even something like a concussion is exacerbated by fear, which causes the body's channels to constrict. When we identify the specific fear a person is harboring and resolve that internal conflict, miraculous physical recovery can follow—recovery that conventional medicine often struggles to explain.

Destructive addictions—smoking, alcohol, drugs—are merely symptoms of internal conflict. There is always a root cause. If a habit cannot be broken through conscious willpower, it means the root is buried in the subconscious. Addressing it requires a certain kind of heroism, demanding that a person walk directly into the fire of their own pain. Sometimes, people reach the edge of their terror and beg to stop, unable to go any further.

After acceptance comes the replacement of the

negative with the positive. Language dictates reality. If you stop calling a crisis a "disaster" and re-label it an "adventure," that linguistic shift changes the tone, and eventually the meaning, of the experience. The moment I changed the meaning of my imprisonment, the psychological weight vanished. In an adventure, I am the hero. In a disaster, I am just a victim. Reframing is a simple psychological tool, but it is the key to maintaining balance in this world.

Ultimately, every event is just a memory, and your perception of that memory is highly malleable. When a person shifts their perspective, their entire reality shifts. It often turns out that their original worldview was an illusion, shaped entirely by other people's words and the resulting emotional pain. Once a person achieves acceptance, the emotional fracture heals, and they naturally see the experience differently. People can survive unimaginable horrors, accept them, extract the growth, and eventually become beacons who teach others how to navigate the darkness.

These tools sound simple, but they are the most effective methods I have ever found. After my release, I studied at the American Academy of Hypnosis, where I refined advanced clinical techniques. But clinical methods require a trained specialist. When you are sitting alone in a freezing cell in the middle of a crisis, you don't have a

therapist. You need raw, simple techniques that work right then and there. I had tried countless meditations and affirmations, but they failed because they never actually addressed the root emotion. You must confront the emotion directly.

That is how I forged a toolkit of highly practical exercises that I *know* work. Every person processes the world differently—some are analytical, others are highly emotional—so I tailor the technique to the individual. Explaining exactly *how* these exercises work in writing is difficult; they must be experienced. But in my own case, I felt the venom gradually losing its potency: blinding anger diluted into hatred, hatred faded into aggression, aggression cooled into indifference, and finally, acceptance blossomed. And from the high ground of acceptance, you can objectively analyze your mistakes and extract the vital lessons.

Today, science understands trauma better than ever. We understand PTSD and the splintering of identity. When a person is subjected to a critical shock, it physically impacts the brain. Science has shown that severe stress creates a "Hamer focus" in the brain—a literal lesion. Based on the location of this damage, you can predict which organ in the body will begin to fail, because each brain region governs a specific physical system. Everything we endure leaves a scar on both the soul and the tissue. But through radical acceptance, we can trigger the

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process of profound healing.

12. THE EXCHANGE

In late December 2017, a major prisoner exchange took place between the DNR and Ukraine. Eleven men from our camp were on the roster. At that point, I still didn't have a smuggled phone, but we were allowed a weekly call to our families. They stayed in constant contact with the POW headquarters and relayed intel about who made the cut. That was how I learned my name was on the list.

At the time, Chudik, two other inmates, and I were serving our two-week punishment in the Pit over the mutiny against the *kozel*. But the day before the exchange, the guards came and pulled the other three out. I was left behind. At the last second, my name had been crossed off. I later learned it was an order straight from Zakharchenko: as long as I was breathing, I was staying there.

My prison saga dragged on while others walked free. That period was agonizing. I was genuinely happy for the brothers who won their freedom, but the realization that they were leaving while I remained behind was devastating. I had absolutely zero desire to spend the next fourteen and a half

years rotting in that concrete hellscape.

After finishing my stint in the Pit, I returned to our barracks. There were only four of us left. The atmosphere was somber, but we stubbornly clung to the faith that another exchange would come.

Two years later, in December 2019, rumors began sweeping through the camp again. The air crackled with tension. Everyone could feel the tectonic plates shifting, and the inmates whispered their predictions in the yard. Every passing day felt like a century.

By then, I had secured a phone and was actively communicating with the outside world. With every new text message from my family, my heart hammered against my ribs. When I received confirmation that I was officially on the list, a chaotic cocktail of emotions hit me: profound relief, explosive joy, but also a creeping, cold uncertainty. What came next? What kind of world was waiting for me outside the razor wire? After everything my mind and body had endured, would I even be able to reintegrate into normal society?

The other men on the list exchanged looks of silent, heavy understanding. Some were ecstatic; others were lost in their own heads, unable to process the reality of their luck. But we were all bound together by the exact same hopes and terrors.

My name was called over the loudspeaker. As I walked across the camp toward the administration

building, a low murmur rolled through the yards.

“Are you leaving? Is it true?”

Men who had been quietly eating their lunch dropped their spoons and turned to watch me. In their eyes, I saw everything—genuine happiness for me, mixed with a crushing, desperate longing for their own freedom. One of the older lifers raised a hand in a silent salute. I returned the gesture. A few guys rushed over to wish me luck, begging me not to forget them once I was back in the real world.

By the time I reached the administration building, I felt like I was standing on the precipice of a new reality. That short walk across the dirt yard felt like crossing a bridge between two dimensions. As I signed the release documents, the suffocating weight I had carried for years simply evaporated. Suddenly, the world looked blindingly bright, bursting with infinite possibilities.

I walked out of the building feeling completely reborn. It wasn't just the anticipation of freedom; it was something vastly deeper. It felt as if every cell in my body and every atom of my soul had suddenly been unshackled. I was free. I was going home to the people I loved, far away from the terror and sadism of the colony. I was ready for the next chapter.

In that moment, I finally understood the absolute necessity of believing in yourself and your destiny. The concrete walls, the iron bars, the barbed

wire—none of it mattered anymore. A power was radiating from my core that no chains could ever hold.

Many of the inmates froze when they saw my face. They could see the transformation. My freedom felt like a shockwave sweeping across the camp, physically touching everyone. By the time I reached my cell to gather my things, I was practically vibrating. I wanted to dance. The flood of emotion and the sheer hunger for life were intoxicating.

My cellmates watched me pack. Their eyes were heavy with pain, envy, and a quiet despair. My explosive joy only sharpened the blade of their own suffering, a brutal reminder of the freedom that remained entirely out of their reach. Some of them would undoubtedly spend decades in those cells—perhaps the rest of their lives. That realization landed on my chest like an anvil.

I desperately wanted my story to serve as a beacon in their endless night. I wanted them to know that if one of us could walk out of this hell, the door was technically open for all of them.

Spending my final hours in that cell, I felt a bizarre wave of gratitude. Those cold walls had been my tomb, but they had also been my monastery. In that brutal isolation, I was forced to dive into the darkest trenches of my own mind. I processed my trauma and discovered that true wealth has absolutely nothing to do with external circumstances. In that

tiny concrete box, I had finally met my true self.

Some people might scoff at the idea that the greatest enlightenment is born in the cruelest conditions. But it was in that maximum-security isolation that I learned to value inner clarity, spiritual strength, and the raw beauty of simply being alive.

The exchange took place on December 29, 2019. That date is permanently burned into my DNA.

We were jolted awake at 6:00 AM, long before sunrise. A guard pulled me out of the Pit; the others were extracted from the barracks, and we were marched to the processing building. During the final search, the guards confiscated one of my notebooks—my personal diary, filled with my poetry and philosophical reflections.

We stepped out into the freezing yard. A fleet of *avtozaks* —armored prison trucks with tiny barred windows—was waiting, engines idling in the dark. We were loaded into the steel compartments, and the convoy rolled out toward Maiorsk. None of us knew exactly what was waiting ahead. We rode in absolute silence, each man trapped inside his own racing mind.

The drive felt endless. Every memory of my past and every desperate hope for the future blurred into a single, chaotic stream of consciousness. Finally, the air brakes hissed and the trucks lurched to a halt. We were marched into a checkpoint.

Under the flickering, dim light of fluorescent bulbs, they photographed us and rolled our fingerprints. Standing in that bleak room, I felt acutely aware that I was nothing more than a statistic—a barcode in a massive geopolitical chess game.

Soon, representatives from the Red Cross, who were mediating the exchange, arrived. We were ushered into a tent where they asked if we had any medical complaints and verified that we actually wanted to proceed with the exchange. After we confirmed, armed guards escorted us toward the final demarcation line.

The physical exchange happened rapidly, though every single second seemed to happen in slow motion. The tension was suffocating; we all knew stories of exchanges being aborted at the very last second, with the prisoners loaded back onto the trucks and returned to the camps. But finally, they lined us up. Prisoners from the Ukrainian side were marched forward. The order was given, and we walked across the line and boarded the Ukrainian bus.

As the bus put it into gear and rolled toward Kramatorsk, the reality finally hit me. The war was over. I had survived.

Driving through Ukrainian territory, I experienced a sensation that language fails to capture. The oppressive gloom, the perpetual terror, and the crushing psychological gravity of the DNR simply

dissolved, burning off like morning fog in the sun. The world outside the bus windows looked hyper-real, vibrating with the electric energy of freedom. Every tree, every rock, and every passing face looked incredibly vivid. I hadn't just come home; my soul had finally found sanctuary.

In Kramatorsk, we boarded a transport plane to Kharkiv, and from there, transferred to a larger jet bound for Kyiv. We touched down at Boryspil International Airport that evening. Despite the crushing exhaustion of the journey, stepping onto the tarmac in Kyiv was pure euphoria.

President Volodymyr Zelensky met us directly on the runway. He shook every man's hand, looking us in the eye, and told us how critical it was for the nation to bring its citizens home. His voice carried genuine warmth and relief; it wasn't just a political formality.

That night marked the absolute beginning of my new life. My days in captivity had been a brutal, grinding nightmare. But the fire hadn't turned me to ash—it had forged my purpose. I realized the human mind is an unimaginably powerful weapon, fully capable of rewriting its own code, healing its own fatal wounds, and architecting its own destiny. Standing on the tarmac, my mission crystallized: I was going to take everything I learned in the dark, build my own methodology, and teach others how to survive.

13. THE TRIAL

Sometime later, I found myself sitting in a courtroom, attending the trial of Palych—the chief torturer of the DNR.

This was the man who called himself Hades, reveling in his role as the god of the underworld. He had systematically brutalized and mutilated Ukrainian prisoners with sadistic glee. Yet, eventually, he decided to flee the DNR and seek refuge in Ukraine. Perhaps he felt the political ground crumbling beneath his boots, or perhaps he arrogantly believed he could reinvent himself in a new city. Regardless, his gamble failed. He was hunted down and arrested by Ukrainian authorities.

Seeing Palych sitting in the defendant's cage was surreal. My memory of him was terrifyingly vivid: roughly six feet tall, built like a tank, with heavy, brutal fists, dark hair, a fleshy nose, and dead black eyes. He drank heavily, and his mood was incredibly volatile, capable of swinging from jovial laughter to homicidal rage in a fraction of a second. But sitting behind the glass, he looked entirely different. He looked small, lost, and pathetic, staring at the floor

to avoid the eyes burning into him from the gallery.

Although the hearings were closed to the general public, the courtroom was packed. Everyone wanted to see justice brought down on the man who had become the ultimate symbol of sadism and betrayal. The atmosphere in the room was highly combustible. Witness testimonies, forensic evidence, legal arguments—I absorbed every word, trying to X-ray Palych's mind to see if he felt an ounce of remorse.

One day, the prosecutor turned to me and asked a direct question: *"In your opinion, what punishment should this man receive for his crimes?"*

In that moment, the immense gravity of the situation hit me. I looked down at the legal documents scattered on the table in front of me, as if they might offer a script. But the paper was silent. I realized that no one else could make this moral judgment for me.

Just hearing the name *Palych* triggered a massive, tangled knot of emotions. Every captured businessman, every political prisoner, and every soldier had been strapped to his iron table. He was a master of his dark craft; he knew exactly how to inflict enough agony to extract a confession from a stone. He possessed zero moral limits. Two men were tortured to death right in front of us, and God only knows how many others he buried.

Whenever Palych went on a bender, or whenever he

received bad news, he would storm down into the political block and unleash hell. He beat us mercilessly, systematically dismantling us physically and psychologically. He specialized in crushing the very core of a man's dignity, leaving his victims so deeply humiliated that they often felt like outcasts even among their own friends. There is no surgical thread in the world that can stitch up wounds to the soul like that.

That was Palych. Perhaps he was too intellectually stunted to comprehend the magnitude of his own cruelty. Or, terrifyingly, perhaps he understood exactly what he was doing and simply enjoyed it, allowing the sadism to become his core identity.

And yet, like all of us, he was once an innocent child. What catastrophic sequence of events transforms a human being into a monster? Was it a violent childhood, a toxic environment, a fractured family, or an underlying psychiatric disorder? Or a lethal cocktail of them all?

The fact that Palych derived deep, visceral pleasure from the suffering of others strongly indicated severe psychopathology—antisocial personality disorder, or clinical sadism. In that psychological state, a man operates completely devoid of empathy or conscience, capable of inflicting horrific trauma without a shred of guilt.

When society completely collapses—when the rule of law evaporates and moral guardrails are

removed—these dark, dormant impulses are suddenly "unlocked." An individual feels insulated by the chaos, acting as an anonymous weapon for a larger political machine. Or perhaps it is a purely social phenomenon; absolute power and zero accountability can corrupt a man until he becomes an instrument of pure evil. From a philosophical standpoint, it simply comes down to free will: he made the conscious, moral choice to become a butcher.

What creates a monster? The question is ultimately unanswerable. But it is critical to state clearly: *explanation is not exoneration*. Palych actively chose to be the architect of human suffering. Systematically violating a person's basic human rights and deliberately inflicting agony crosses every boundary of the social contract. It rips apart the very fabric of humanity.

Can a man like that ever be rehabilitated? Can he ever atone? If there was even a microscopic spark of self-awareness or doubt inside him, it could be the first step toward true repentance. But atonement requires far more than admitting guilt; it is an active, agonizing process of making amends that can take a lifetime—and sometimes, it is simply impossible.

The fact that Palych casually fled to Ukraine highlights his profound lack of self-awareness. It showed a staggering arrogance, a genuine belief in

his own untouchability. Men like him rarely view themselves as the villains of the story, even when standing in chains before a judge.

The ultimate irony is that in fleeing the DNR, he couldn't flee from his own mind. Regardless of the judge's verdict, Palych is permanently chained to his atrocities. Perhaps the most excruciating punishment is simply forcing him to live out his days in a cage, acutely aware of the devastation he caused, with absolutely zero chance of ever making it right.

Or perhaps his mind will never achieve that level of awareness. Regardless, analyzing the psychological machinery that created him is a vital step for his victims. Understanding the monster helps the survivors find balance and begin the long, slow process of healing.

As the trial progressed, the gallery thirsted for vengeance. Part of me felt profound relief knowing this animal would never see the sun again. But mostly, his story served as a grim cautionary tale about the absolute depths of human degradation.

When the prosecutor asked me to dictate the fate of the man who had turned my life into a living hell, all these philosophical dilemmas collided in my brain. What is the correct mathematical equation for justice here? Execution? That felt too fast, too easy. Life in solitary confinement? Too cruel, making us no better than him. Or would leniency be

a grotesque insult to his victims?

I pictured the faces of the men he had tortured. I remembered the blinding terror, the agony, and the humiliation in their eyes. Part of my brain demanded that he suffer exactly as we had. Yet, a much deeper part of my soul violently rejected that instinct.

Standing in the quiet courtroom, staring at Palych through the glass, I asked myself a hard question: *Am I suffering from Stockholm syndrome?* Why wasn't I consumed by a blinding, homicidal rage? Why was I looking at my former torturer and feeling a strange, hollow sense of pity?

It created a profound internal conflict. I knew my reaction looked exactly like classic hostage psychology. But as I analyzed it, I realized it was something else entirely. It was a defense mechanism—my integrated mind protecting my nervous system from being dragged back into the trauma. I felt pity because I was looking at a wretched, broken creature who had permanently damned his own soul.

I watched the other victims take the stand. They shook uncontrollably. They screamed at Palych, completely consumed by their trauma, their rage spilling over. I stood there, pulse steady, entirely calm.

That was the moment I truly understood the difference between a man who is trapped inside his

trauma, and a man who has processed it. If I hadn't done the excruciating psychological integration work in my cell, I would have been screaming at the glass, too. But because I had descended into my own personal hell and slaughtered my own demons, I viewed the world through a different lens.

My belief that every life carries a divine spark gave me a radical perspective: perhaps I *needed* to be strapped to that iron table. Perhaps the absolute destruction of my old life was the only way to force me to evolve. Despite the horror, it was the torture chamber that ultimately introduced me to my true self.

Looking the prosecutor in the eye, I understood the immense moral weight of the moment. Suggesting a punishment meant choosing a side in the eternal war of polarities. Did I want to become the apex predator, the big fish eagerly devouring the weaker one in the name of vengeance?

Sitting in that courtroom, I knew with absolute certainty that karma is real. No man escapes the consequences of his actions. When the bill comes due, no bunker is deep enough to hide you from justice. But I also believed that even in the most radioactive, corrupted souls, there remains a fractional possibility of redemption. Sometimes, against all logic, they deserve mercy. Perhaps Palych's true punishment wouldn't come from a judge's gavel, but from the agonizing, internal war

between his conscience and his demons.

But I had to make my choice, honestly and with a clear conscience.

"I leave that to the court," I answered.

Those words were vastly heavier than a simple refusal to answer the question. It was a public declaration that, even after staring directly into the eyes of pure evil, I refused to let it extinguish my humanity. I wasn't entirely sure of my own feelings, but I knew that if I demanded a man's destruction, that choice would stain my conscience forever.

And that is the ultimate tragedy of Palych. The opportunity for repentance, reflection, and moral transformation no longer belongs to him. It belongs entirely to us—the survivors he left behind. That is the true price of our survival.

Palych's trial is still ongoing. The prosecution has requested a fifteen-year sentence.

CONCLUSION

At the very beginning of this book, I stated that my imprisonment became the most productive period of my life. Without it, I would never have become the man I am today.

Naturally, surviving a crucible like that alters your DNA. When you are dragged through the fire of a critical, life-or-death reality, your entire value system is violently rebooted. You change how you interact with people. You realize the true weight of your words. You stop worshiping money and material things. The "massive problems" of your past life suddenly look incredibly trivial. You learn to fiercely value freedom, and the simple, profound miracle of drawing breath.

All the petty, everyday anxieties simply burn away. You realize they are just noise. You learn to cherish existence itself, even if you have lost absolutely everything you own, because you understand the fundamental truth: *You are still alive, which means you can rebuild the empire from the dirt.* I vividly remember the days immediately following the exchange. I didn't want wealth or status. I just

wanted to walk down a street. I just wanted to breathe the air. I just wanted to taste life.

Today, I look back on my captivity as the most valuable era of my existence. It forcefully rerouted my destiny, handed me a definitive mission, and gave my life absolute meaning.

But I want to make one thing perfectly clear: *Prison gives a man nothing good*. I would not wish it on my worst enemy, and I would never want to go back.

A year or two of solitude can be beneficial. It forces a man to sit quietly and examine his own soul. But anything beyond that requires superhuman psychological resistance. In the camp, you learn to hide, manipulate, and deceive simply to survive the day. The penal system is not designed to rehabilitate a man or elevate his consciousness. It is a machine engineered exclusively to break him, to force him to lie, and to seamlessly integrate him into a subculture of predators and prey.

When I was thrown into the abyss, a quiet, internal voice saved my life. I made a conscious, ironclad decision: I will never stop learning. I will relentlessly train my mind. I will choose to believe that the universe placed me in this hell specifically to forge me into steel. A sword is only hardened if it is plunged into both the blazing fire and the freezing water.

But men possessing the psychological fortitude to study, read, and evolve inside a maximum-security

camp are incredibly rare. The environment actively cultivates a criminal, parasitic mindset. More often than not, even a highly decent man will eventually adopt the law of the jungle and carry that toxic programming back out into the free world. Very few people are capable of extracting fuel for growth from pure agony.

My transformation didn't stop when I walked out of the prison gates. Initially, I returned to my roots in business, successfully rebuilding the solid-waste recycling facility I had lost. But I couldn't shake my intense focus on psychology. I dove heavily into the study of clinical hypnotherapy.

It was during this study that my true calling crystallized. My mission was to hunt down and help every single person who found themselves trapped in a psychological nightmare similar to mine. Because almost no one has the tools to survive the catastrophic internal collapse caused by severe trauma alone.

Even I—a man who genuinely believed he had processed, survived, and achieved absolute acceptance of his torture—ran into a massive wall of psychological blowback in the free world. I was hit with severe post-traumatic stress. I battled chronic anxiety. I was hunted by visceral, terrifying nightmares where I was being stabbed and slashed, unable to run away. Even after all the rigorous internal work I did in my cell, the internal war raged

on.

It was only during my advanced clinical training in hypnotherapy that absolute, final integration occurred. That was the moment I fully embraced my mission, opened my practice, and built my project.

It was the darkest, most agonizing period of my life. And it was the most valuable. The brutal solitary confinement that was designed to shatter my mind became my ultimate dojo. Locked inside four concrete walls where I possessed absolutely nothing, I found everything: brilliant teachers, the psychological tools to hack my own mind, and a reservoir of power I never knew existed.

The absolute darkness turned out to be the greatest school for the light.

Today, my job is to guide people out of the most terrifying, hopeless labyrinths imaginable. This is my mission, and it brings me profound joy. I live for the exact moment when the light of life finally returns to the eyes of a person who firmly believed they were permanently broken. Experiencing that moment just once makes the entire nightmare I survived worth it.

But one man only has two hands; I cannot reach everyone who is suffering. So, I took every lesson I extracted from the torture chamber, everything my teachers taught me, and my years of clinical practice, and synthesized them into a single, unified

methodology.

I call it Kuznya Sily — *The Forge of Strength*.

It is a tactical methodology you can learn and apply yourself. It teaches you how to dismantle your trauma, rebuild your psychological armor, and become unbreakable. It is designed to be passed down—to your children, your family, and your bloodline. It exists so that families can become fortresses. It exists so that men and women know exactly how to walk through the fire and survive any trial the universe throws at them.

I counted 1,341 days.

I wrote this book so that you wouldn't have to count yours.

APPENDIX. POEMS

Translator's note: these 47 poems were written in captivity, in notebooks, without editing for form. The Russian originals are raw, irregular free verse – off-rhyme, broken meter, prison slang mixed with religious and mythological imagery. This translation prioritizes meaning, imagery, and emotional register over rhyme or meter, consistent with the rest of this book's translation approach. A professional poetry translator could later polish these into more formal English verse if desired; nothing below should be read as a final, publication-ready poetic rendering – it is a faithful first-pass translation.

Donetsk

Oh Donetsk, my beloved, I know the color of your soul – yellow and blue, of course, with Poseidon out in front. You knew Hera, you knew Zeus, but you became the apple of discord, and Odysseus's Trojan horse wrapped its plague around you. But I know for certain: you will take up the trident, the mace, and Glory, and tear out the enemy's throat the way Perseus tore the centaur's.

Shame

I know shame — our ancestors taught it to me, and that shame torments me. It knows everything, what's needed and what isn't; it's an ancient spirit, the world's disgrace. Its sound is like my mother's voice, its scheming like the tears of existence. And I — I have accepted it as the spirit of my line, the ancient maker of illusion. Now, from this point on, it is my chorister, my helper, my advisor in matters of war — because it's nothing more than the world's shadow.

To My Beloved

Forgive me — beloved, forgive me. I know you cried in the night, screamed and blamed God, cursed fate, mourning for me there. And how do you live like that, who tells you how? Because I'm in captivity, for long years, and you, my dear, are young, beautiful, and wise. So listen to the voice of your own prophet — understand, and let go. So few words, and so much meaning: I am your angel, and your friend for all time.

Dream

I had a dream, and in it I was hacked to pieces, and I felt that trouble had come. I opened my eyes and understood it was only a dream, but duty calls: forward, go, you're needed. And my heart begs and screams: disaster. I went forward and met the yoke, and that yoke was the Russian spring. My older brother betrayed God, called

the devil to his work, and his work was like death with a scythe — it cut the thread of brotherhood and kinship. And I took up my sword and shouted for battle, and understood that my essence is war.

UE

The convicts shouted AUE, we shouted UE — because we are, at heart, political prisoners, and the essence of that politics is unity. Unity, brotherhood, Ukrainian unity. The separatist shouts “fascists,” Russia scrambles our minds, and I sit here, suffering, rocking, a captive on my own land — because what matters most is unity.

Who Am I

I am what others think. I am what I think of myself. I am dust of the earth, a drop of the sea, I am the Cosmos above. Or maybe I'm not that at all — not what I think right now, not what others think — so who am I? I am the one who is thinking, right now. But this much I know for certain: I am the thing I cannot come to know.

The Horseman of Ruin

I saw the horseman of ruin; he sows chaos across the worlds. His armor is the embodiment of disgrace, his horse a sick plague, his sword a hurricane. — He tears down ancient kingdoms to give life a new stage. And I watch, and I understand: the horseman turned into a beautiful Aphrodite, wrapping himself around the spiral of life. This is how the gods shook me, this is how they

opened my third eye – the constant of the world, the Fibonacci code: I came to know 1.618.

Luck

Do you know what luck really is? Have you ever had that moment? Know this: luck is fortune, and its delicacy is love. We call luck by the name of God – so apply love's formula, brother, and luck will pour out like fortune. Trust your luck, love, don't hold back.

The Heart of the Brave

What is the heart of a brave man? It is fear, guarded by the spirit of a sage. It is the pain of betrayals and lies. It is the torment of an enemy's torture. It is the collapse of false beliefs. It is the path of knowledge, the dogma of existence. It is a friend, faithful for all time. It is Brotherhood, bound by blood. It is the woman who gave her passion. It is a mother's love. It is faith in miracles. It is all of this – the ideas of the brave, of a man who has raised his eyes.

Faith

As long as doubt still lives, there's no room yet for luck – because first place always belongs to only one: the champion. And the Colosseum sets free only one – the gladiator who has defeated his enemy, who does not run from fear, but believes in God and in himself. He understood that doubt is a curse, an ancient spirit of misfortune and falls, while faith and confidence always

bring freedom and fortune.

I Am the Director

I am a magnet, an atom of contemplation; my protons create a whirlwind, a vibration of magnetic pull, bending the course of life to my will. I am the emptiness that dissolves all creation, detonating illusion forever, freeing the heart from suffering, granting freedom for all time. I am courage, I am the armor of God, the chained flesh of titans; alone, I am ready to face the horde, because victory loves only the bold. I am a beast, I am a monster, I am silence; I command these elements — they are only the wings of my ship. I am — I am God, I am the devil, I am contemplation itself, the eternal verse of Shakespeare. My game is movement into transformation. I am the director, and I am the hero of the story.

Hell

Do you know what hell is? Maybe you've heard plenty of tales and legends, maybe you've even read Dante. But I was there while still alive — that place on this earth with a portal down into the underworld, where there is no God, only demons of every kind, and every demon dreams of a throne built out of human bone, feeding day and night on fear, demanding new deaths, always more. Hades — the warden of that ward — a fallen demon, a villain, a traitor to his father's oath, he cuts souls out of people, giving orders to his frenzied devils, binding

people to ropes of pain, to iron tables – to burn, to stab, to carve up the hero. And now it was my turn. The priest performs every rite; I'm chained to the table by iron links. Judas gave up every one of my moves. Hades gave the order, and my armor was stripped away. Do you know what pain is? How amperes tear through flesh? Burning your insides with current, how the screams of your own soul deafen your own ears, how the grinding of broken teeth floods your jaw with blood – that's how I summoned my agony, and they peeled the skin off me alive. But the spirit wasn't broken, even when the body was gone; pain wrapped around every limb. I begged Hades: kill me. Pain pierced my whole body, my heart racing two hundred beats a minute, time lost all meaning, and the demon kept driving in his spikes – this was only the beginning, brother. Everything went dark, there was no more pain, no more words, only emptiness. I opened my eyes, saw the walls of the Plague, and understood: this is Hell. There is no food and no water here, the air poisoned with ammonia, deceit everywhere, on every side, confession ripped out of me with a hook, because I was betrayed by a soul close to me. A day here lasts like an eternity, there is no sun and no moon here, and muscles tear like ropes, bending bones into knots. And I understood: I have to live. I heard the voice of my heart: someone has to keep fighting. Maybe God needs someone still standing. Faith seemed to have failed its charge, but a thought worked a kind of miracle, and the strength of an inner string returned the

power of the spirit — because every path is given as a trial, and the prize, the reward of a hundred men, is called: a body of steel.

To Be or Not to Be

To be or not to be — that is the question. Shakespeare pondered eternity, fell into the trap of life, tangled in the labyrinth of creation. But he called life a game, so a man could move through it like carnival, so that, changing masks every day, each of us could be something special, could look at life differently — because life is a game, and we are all its actors, and the script is simple: to be, to do, to have.

“The Hunt”

I walk the trail, chasing my prey, driving it on, made myself like the great beast — I am a lion in the desert, and only instinct rules over me. I smell the scent of fear, the pounding heart of my prey. I walk the trail and I know falling, and I know pain, know that panic leaves its own tracks, trails that lead the game onward. I know the smell of my prey, that particular sweetness — it is the sweetness of the feast, it is the blood of Victory. I walk the trail; my prey is cornered, trapped. I taste the sweetness, the instant of a lion's roar. Oh, the Hunt, the Great Game, the beast's instinct — a miracle humanity has lost.

“Happy New Year, 2019”

What are you bringing me, and my nation? What thoughts, what tales, what trials? I paint my own confession. The old year was fought in struggle and torment; a treacherous serpent, at its core, took away the breath of freedom, throwing a yoke of chains over me. I am like Prometheus, punished by Zeus; I wait for the raven from dawn on, ready to receive my torment for the choice I made — my homeland. New Year, come on, let's go — announce the long-awaited exchange. Freedom to the Cossack's mace; let its joy roam free, its wide meadow of armor, its song, its beloved sound, the great cry of the free people.

“Judas”

I sit in a storm, a captured hero; Judas's dogs guard my burning. Betrayal chases me in circles; trust is my own whip, turned against me. What gave birth to a young man's betrayal — someone who doesn't understand life, for whom trust is worth nothing? Just as Judas betrayed Jesus for thirty pieces of silver, so this man betrayed every promise, out of the basest of concerns, just to fill his stomach for entertainment, just to buy himself a little more time — staining his own name forever, to be called a dog until the end of time. I wonder what Judas actually felt on his great, black day. And you — what are you thinking, you dog? Know this: retribution is the law. Judas hanged himself in spiritual agony, having understood his terrible sin. And what have you decided, you dog? Remember: forgiveness loves only bloody sweat.

“Reincarnation”

Thought-forms create currents of energy, pouring into the mill-wheels of space; a thought born out of emptiness switches on the bodies of seven realms. A wise man, the maker of the metasphere, having come to know the laws of the cosmos, gives birth to particular desires, submitting them to the laws of retribution. Karma is an inescapable system, one that must, sooner or later, be worked off – sadly, right up until the pulse itself stops. And every second is a scream, an echo of Sanskrit, because the cause is present within the deed, just as the deed carries the essence of its cause, and determinism, the causal chain of consequence, carries within it the laws of balance and the call of retribution – they shaped the character of a man, the character of a past life. His mind is like a cluster of impressions; a samskara has stamped its seal. Oh fate, the consequences of one’s efforts, the result of one’s own free will – as Plato of Athens once claimed, that knowledge is the memory of the samskaras, and the Jews of the Old Testament called John the Baptist an incarnation of Elijah. “I am you,” say the Hindus, explaining rebirth and the wheel of samsara. The force of the current at birth, and its charge, and the soul, seized by Anubis. Whether I lived before, or will live again, I don’t know; there is no happiness, only pure deception, but life, life is an eternal reward – the path of coming to know yourself.

To Be

What does it mean to “be,” and how do you come to know that word about yourself, the foundation and bedrock of all creation? Because the word “be” holds so much meaning in it – even the fifth element, ether, is there within it. The word “be” is the start of every ritual, and life’s very first cry, a young man’s first cry, and the joy that is the reward of existence, and the path, being born right now. But the word “was” is like death with its scythe – it carries only the ashes of what once was; a deathly spirit lives on in that stillness, and the word “was” walks the road of Anubis. And I heard an inner voice say “I will be,” and something wrapped itself around me – illusion wants its own kind of nourishment, but “will be” – that is, in truth, fate, not fantasy, not illusion, not deception.

“Know Yourself”

The path of humankind is bound up with risk and with fortune, and blessed are those who wait through the rising and the setting. And that struggle is wrapped in shadows – the shadows of one’s own spirit. So be the light yourself; come to know your own shadows. And once you know your own shadow, then what will you have left? Isn’t it the light, still, in the spirit of your own body?

Battle for Paradise

Human fear, like a wild beast, lunges and tears at everything around it, and that “around” – that’s the soul, my soul, your soul, the soul of Atman. And the serpent keeps tearing, demanding flesh, growing, demanding more of me. And I understood it all, saw it clearly – I drew out my own eternal Excalibur. I called on the Archangel and said: be with me, by the right of God. Let there be battle, I said. So the angel gave me the wings of a brave warrior; I rose up, swung my sword. The serpent saw and tried to flee, but I caught it, drove my eternal Excalibur through it, and there was roaring, screaming, weeping – and that is how I freed my soul, and found my way back to myself.

Trochee

There once was Choréi, a Japanese old man, who charged the air around him with laughter. Walking out into a field, wading through a stream, he’d start to laugh, and people thought he was sick. “A sane man doesn’t act like that,” the villagers thought. But old Choréi laughed on, charging the space around him, and even the King of Beasts began to laugh, breaking apart his own grief over a lost kingdom. Once the Lion had healed, he said to Choréi: “You are my friend forever.” He understood joy, understood its essence, and got his kingdom back. And people thought him blessed – the one who had come to know the wild beast. Old Choréi kept laughing, charging the air around him, and that day came, when everyone felt the vibration. That’s how the

old Japanese man, Choréi, kept charging the space around him; he became a god, became goodness itself, an ancient Japanese deity.

“My Game”

Currents of life, the difference in potential — without cold, there can be no heat, what’s above can never take the place of what’s below, and death cannot buy its way into life. This is no fantastical inside knowledge, just the labyrinth, the circle of samsara. Whoever understands the wholeness of the monad, who reconciles the night with the light, understands the way out of the wheel of samsara, and calls life a game. Trouble comes to the one who fails to see life as an adventure for the hunter, and evil as just the sharp edge of the circle. Let the Demon into your mouth, and the hellish shard within Paradise will destroy paradise itself. Because evil is only half of the circle, the half that splits ordinary life down the middle.

Captivity

Brother, how do you feel about the lock? When people suffer for an idea, when the food slot is just a leaf for slop, when swagger breaks every road, when the whole sky is nothing but crosses, when concrete works its way into your mind, when a man breaks every rule like a gladiator under Roman whips, when every bone is broken, and your insides tear apart from grief, and damp rot infects your lungs, and traitors watch you

everywhere — so how, then, do we make something worth reading out of human life, and find a unified spirit, and destroy grief through brotherhood, and clarity over swaggar, and give attention to what's human, and put an end to anger? These are the concepts we carry. That's how we live, brother.

Focus

Brother, wherever your thought goes, that's where your direction goes too, and wherever your inner eye looks, that's where your strength goes as well, brother. It will leave you like a small wave, or maybe like a tsunami, carrying with it the noise and grind of fear. So what are you waiting for? What outcome are you hoping for? Decide, my brother, whose side you're really on.

Diamond Body

A diamond body, a completed path, the teaching of an eternal philosophy — to free the soul from the fire of Adam's original sin, to cut down the two-headed serpent with the unity of Eden's apple. And Eve, her body sent by the serpent, received the nectar of forgiveness, and the torments of hell were forgiven; transformation, the beginning of a kingdom, is the result of the inner Eye. Knowledge, the brotherhood of law, the tablets of the Keepers of the gate — as Christ the Blessed once explained the stone of Moses, casting out demons rightly, he worked miracles through joy, and glorified paradise, filling the commandments with light, pointing

the way to heaven — knowledge, bliss, eternity.

Battle

There was a terrible battle; I died, to many people. Word spread through the crowd, crows gathered over the corpse. I taste the yoke of the unclean; they devoured the flesh of deceit's sin. I found the nectar of resurrection, rose up into the sky, met Zeus, heard the Father's Covenant, accepted forgiveness through baptism. Hephaestus forged me the armor of God; an archangel mounted Pegasus and taught me how to fly. Ares taught me the art of battle; I trained alongside Achilles, joined the ranks of the immortal host. Now, holding a shield, chainmail, an Excalibur, and a faithful Pegasus, I ran Cerberus through, and gave rise to great deeds. Twelve demons will die; titans will fall before me.

“Know Yourself”

How do I become a lucky, happy man? Where is the key to the fairy tale of existence — at sea, on land, or maybe in the sky? I honestly don't know. But one wise man said: know yourself, know the scriptures of the Vedanta, and knowledge will free you from torment, will give you clarity of understanding about the meaning and path of earthly life, and that path leads to the immortality of the soul.

Paradise

I've heard so much about Paradise, the magical city up

in the heavens, the seventh heaven, as our ancestors called it, pointing seekers of reward toward it. God lives there, ruler of every universe, a miracle-worker and an eccentric. There, the air fills up with desire, and every breath gives birth to a scent. There, thoughts are golden muses; there, every soul is a genius, a sage, making great discoveries, giving light to infinity. There, interests are everywhere, all at once; the energy of joy floats in the air; there, everything living in this world finds bliss as the companion of its path. God walks there, swaying gently, thinking something over to himself, and the world changes its colors, and everyone feels the answer. Oh God, how beautiful it is here — and it immediately seems like everything down below is wrong. But the Creator said that thoughts are power, and the door is already within us.

Illness

Illness — what exactly are you? Where do you come from, what's your trail? As a child I felt no grief; I was rarely sick, and only from hardship. Illness — who exactly are you, bringing so much misery to people? And who gave you the right to strip away the last of a soul's years? Illness — what should I do? I don't know. How do I ask the world for peace, to loosen your tight grip and knock away your shackles? Illness, accept this offering, this peak: health is something you need too; I'll give it to you, and more besides, because you're its husband, and it belongs to you forever. Illness, now I understand what

you really are: you are love, the love that I rejected.

The Higher Will

The Higher Will, the engine of progress, the result of forced blows — it seems like it hurts terribly, but that's just an invention for the weak. Whoever sees no further than his own tears, his own chains flooding the chambers of his mind, begging the gods for forgiveness — but the Higher Will is a decision from above, the creation of the highest clouds, forgiveness for the one who never found his own will. And all of this is yours, by right — a spark of the Great Fire, a weapon that frees the slave.

Debt

I owe, and I will pay. Let the Lord direct my every move; let truth be my judge. My first debt is to my father and mother, my family, all the angels, the saviors of my universe, to whom I must pay love, down to the very last drop, support, with my own back. So that, through the ages, they remain, so that their descendants know their names. And my friends will receive the fraternal code, the commandments of knightly duty, the art of understanding that still remains for me to learn, so that I can soar in my own courage, proudly call myself a man. And now we come to others — strangers, colors, to the flickering game of fate, to acts of partial conscience, and I will act the way I want others to act toward me, and let this moment be my judge — the fruit of my own

considered deeds.

Conversation with Darkness

I opened a door and saw twelve beings, sitting in a circle, looking at me, and I met them with a question: what do you want from me? One of them rose halfway and said: "I am the sage, Plato of Athens. You summoned me while studying elvish argon." A second stood up like a mountain: "I am a warrior and titan of Olympus, called when you asked for help." And I looked on, unable to understand whether I'd lost my mind or died. And a third being, without rising, whispered in a beautiful woman's voice: "Don't you understand? I am Venus. You asked me for love and happiness." I press a needle into my heart, and the pain gave me back myself. And a fourth demon laughed: "I am a healer, Avicenna the alchemist. You are healthy, but the time has come to answer for your own desires, because I helped you learn the foundations of philosophical knowledge." "I will answer," I said, "but let me understand — there are still too many questions left." And so I spoke with each of them, asking every one of them for forgiveness, for failing to see the light, the hint of righteous laws. All of them left me, all my torments; I received the key to the treasure. One dream, one road, and a thousand deeds still ahead of me, and I must answer for every one of them, and there will be a judgment at the end of the road, but that judgment holds no fear for me now — I have received the defense of truth.

“A Mad Desire Is Slavery”

A mad desire is slavery, the worship of some chosen dream that shuts down the mind and severs the thread of the divine wave. And this feeling is unease; I heard a scream, inside, and my body shook with grief, sensing the coming collapse of the wall, warning me of it, intuitively. But madness flooded my mind, and my thoughts became like wild horses, carrying me toward the edge of the abyss, reminding me that I am a slave to my own dream, an unwilling spirit, bound by desire. Desires — how strong you are, how much power runs through your veins, how much selfishness lies behind you, how many fates you’ve broken, fates that never reached their dream. And I tamed my mind, took desire firmly by the reins, and eased the weight on my heart; freedom filled my breath. The slave’s chains fell away; I saw the right code. I am the master of my own desires, the victor over worldly cares.

Boomerang

If you found some money, or something of great value, wait for the owner of that dream and give him back his fortune, and you will see bliss, the joy of a human soul, and you will earn good luck, and every debt you owe will be repaid. But if you defile that act and make someone else’s happiness your own, you will lose your own soul, and hand your own happiness to someone else, and no one, ever, will bring your luck back to you, and no help

will ever come to you again, and you will keep giving away your happiness until you've paid back someone else's happiness twice over.

Music of the Soul

I looked back over years full of complete emptiness; I blame my misfortunes on the grief in my own mind. I've learned my lessons, paid the price in full; my heart weeps from its own torment, ashamed to look back. And I gathered my strength and looked the demon in the eye, so that he would no longer rule over me, so that he'd be overthrown by my own game, and his grip on my fate would go dark. My experience is my wealth now – a game of madness and desire, the rise, the fall of a dream, the path of the human soul. From my own words, I take flight on the wings of a sound wave; from my own words, I fade into the melody of my own soul. Who will commission my music, give the conductor his cue, so he can play for me the great, eternal hits?

Signs

Signs of fate, the screams of the universe, the collapse of a human destiny – I didn't see the understanding when birds flew into the smoke. I didn't feel the suffering when the house burned to the ground in my dream. And all I did was curse and say that it was all nonsense, the superstition of old tales, a story meant to scare children, and I laughed at that whole idea, until life sent me a sign, and everything fell apart, like in some terrible

fable. And the signs made their own screams, and I sit here, thinking about life, at the broken trough of existence, and now I wait for new signs, so I won't miss fortune's flash — because it's such a brief shimmer, a swift, magical run, the golden antelope's lyre, the invisible race of fate. And now I am like a skilled hunter, laying snares for life's own signs, hoping to catch life's great prize — the feat called: I managed it.

To a Friend

Good day, my dear friend, today is the day of your star, the birthday of a titan in human flesh. You were born into trials; your mission is law, a great work worth reading, for the sake of humanity, a solution to human troubles. I know for certain that many respect you, and some of them, you make shiver; your force of will destroys their crooked path. I wish you luck, good fortune, ingots of happiness, the wisdom of Socrates' roads, victories like Achilles', and women, plenty of them, and beautiful. Be kind to many, but trust no one.

Strong Desires

A strong desire slows down time; waiting becomes a taut string, pulled tight by the torment of the game, the urgency of wanting your dream fulfilled. But whatever is meant to happen will happen, exactly, up ahead, and it can't be born any sooner than it's meant to be born, at the end of its road. A strong desire slows down time; it changes the course of the machine of time, distorts the

shape of space, throwing small things off to the side. But every small thing is part of something greater, the seed of a great tree of fate, the beginning of a great beginning, the meaning of the human game. Here and now — this is the great answer, the peace of the human soul. To free your heart from desire means to find freedom, on your own path.

Strictness

Strictness — the foundation of upbringing. Driven into a corner by shouting, a person with no understanding yet, an inexplicable wound in a young soul. A spark of understanding pushes us to make our own run of mistakes, and we, without understanding, give strictness its own dawn. A dawn of resentment and shame, a thick trail of hatred, when a soul is shattered into pieces, it gives the wrong answer. Repeating these words forever, I won't commit mistakes like these again, and strictness gives birth to the roots of cowardice, drives a person away from victory, closing off, forever, the search for the lands of the gods, the adventures of wondrous nobility, the chains of a heroic fate. Oh, parent — know, from now on, that strictness is an evil, a torment for a young soul, and have patience of spirit, and let your fruit grow through gentleness, and don't wound the young creation — understand the true basis of your own strictness. It should grow from the heart, in soft soil, without passion, and strictness, only when paired with a smile in the heart, creates a person

without chains.

Once Upon a Time, Without Grief

Once upon a time, without grief, life rolled on, with the look of fortune. I played at my own luck – money, women, limousines, the passing show of a young soul. My goals were made of gold; I searched for Aladdin's lamp, took women only from the highest heavens – that's what I used to think, once, and guess at. But life, of course, is an interesting thing; it promises so many rewards, and just as many nasty pits – today you're on top, tomorrow you've vanished. But there are no victories without defeats, and wisdom appears only where the note of the Great Orchestra never plays false for us. Every instrument is tuned; the mechanism is polished down to the smallest detail by the daily game of chasing luck, a person, together with their own fate – and fate, from the Hebrew, means the consequence of a person's own deeds. What you sow, you reap – the law of the biblical Testament. And all of it happened to me – there were highs, and there were falls, and the road led me to the great parables of the Creator. Full clarity arrived; my soul was freed from its chains. Salvation for a man lies in God; fortune is nothing but His love.

Hymn to the Cossack Hero

(translated from the Ukrainian)

**Hey, Cossack, brave knight
of the yellow-and-blue land,
your land roars and weeps
under a foreign boot.**

The cursed Muscovite tramples you

Pseudo-Patriots

(translated from the Ukrainian)

These are hags who look like men, sharp with their words, and they say so much, just to justify their own existence. They carry the whole world on their shoulders, and every fool, every idiot, they see everything about everyone, and they've got advice for everyone – how to look further ahead, what to do, and how to milk it. But the moment real trouble arrives and people actually need attention, they all suddenly turn into cowards, plug up their eyes and ears, and run, tail between their legs. That's exactly what they are.

The Hero's Path

The hero's path is hard and thorny, and there's no other way to walk it; you'll have to fight, to claw your way through, for your life, if you want to rise as a hero. You, hero, are always alone in this life, one against everyone, and everyone against you, and in this battle there is no victory – the hero is denied his ending, forever. Betrayal is his eternal companion, sharpening its axes day and night, never letting the hero's muscles rest on his own road. And no matter how his heart grieves over people's baseness and cowardice, the hero is fated to fall if he trusts his own tears. Faith and betrayal are two sides of one coin, but it isn't chance that decides the round – it's the foundation of a man's own morals, a pyramid of unresolved hardship. A hero, maybe, has to be a machine

— but how do you endure that kind of pain, how do you grow in a garden of malice, when poison is poured into your soul? But surely there's a reason for it — steel only melts in fire, losing its old shape in the world, so it can become tempered steel in a blade. And so the hero has to smelt down his own weakness, temper his blades with that strength, fill himself to the brim with courage, so that wisdom can finally rise. Because a hero cannot exist without battle — the essence of his feat is a game, a shift in the history of his nation. And there must be some reason for all of it — hero, where do you find your own toasts, why do you need all these battles, these wounds, this pain, these lost loved ones, this fire of memorial obelisks in the soul? I don't know, I can't find the answer, what the true essence of a hero's race really is — are you a hero, or a tyrant for all time? But this battle lasts an eternity, and only the victor keeps circling, wrapped in the glory of eternal prizes.

Spleen

How sad I sometimes feel; melancholy takes hold of me; my heart fills up with grief, and I fear the eruption of my own longing. It raises up oceans, stirs the desolate seafloor into a rage, lifts up piles of debris, days long since drowned, undecomposed corpses of old ideas, ships that lost their way. All of it is already an avalanche; the eruption gave birth to a scream — my soul opened up its roar, I roar and I weep, in torment; longing has won the first round. And however much has spilled out into the

open, I see no justice anywhere, at all; I am left alone, only with myself, and there is no one else left. Goodness itself has been swallowed by plague, concepts have lost their meaning, there is no truth, only grief, my morality crucified by pain, and everything that was once sacred is now ash, and there's no way to get that loss back. It's long past time to change my God, if he crucified his own son and allowed that torment to happen, so that his own son would die from hellish pain. And he cried out, "Father, why have you forsaken me?" And what was the moral of it, what was the son's feat, why create days like these? You could have just told everyone plainly, shown yourself off a little, and become a real god without any of that. But no — for some reason, that isn't allowed. God restrains himself everywhere, and comes only in dreams, and even then, only to chosen creations, once in a thousand ages, and even that has survived only in legend, and even that, a distorted motif. That's how sad this Spleen really is.

Deliberation

Deliberation — the armor of God, a concept forged in fire, knowledge of the right course, an answer granted by the gods. Deliberation — because this is the strength of the mind, a bridge between heaven and earth, an ambush for the reckless novice who never thought his move through, who carelessly babbles his nonsense out of his own youth and foolishness. He thinks he knows the trick already, without diving into the depth of things. So

he floats on the surface, empty, never knowing the depths, the open spaces, gathering nothing but garbage instead of the gifts he actually needed. So deliberation is a real blessing, and knowledge is the foundation of its words, the many-faced image of God, an Olympus that waits only for the wise.

Ostracism

To be rejected by everyone — only he is ready for that, and him alone, and he accepts it with grace, and finds meaning in it, and strength for struggle, for flourishing. And now I am one of them, part of the caste of the unwanted. And everyone who once surrounded me has now fled, weaving slander and spite, whether out of fear, or simply misunderstanding. I can't understand a lowly soul; I've always reached for the heights, where the air is fresh, the views so beautiful, that all you can think about is that height, and your own calling. And contemplation is both the path and the meaning, and blessing is the foundation of all creation. Yes, I've given birth to many thoughts, this lonely spirit of suffering, and for now I am alone with it, learning its thoughts and its desires, and in this there is an entire labyrinth through which I wander, of my own free will. Because I know there's only one way out — through pain, through suffering, through the tempering of muscle and bone, through filth, through misfortune, through torment. Because whoever is pure of soul and seeks repentance can make it through that labyrinth — the one given to us as a trial.

On Socrates

People, I've been thinking about the feat of that wisest of elders, about Socrates, that Athenian talisman. The Pythia said of him, without hiding it, that he was the wisest of all men, Socrates, the herald of the Daemon, speaking with a voice inside him, learning about the gods of Athens, speaking of honor and of virtue, teaching people how to live by the right current of things. He spoke of morality as if it were the very air of righteous birth, of the poison of wrong behavior, of the lowliness, the vileness of people, of betrayal in service of evil, of wealth accumulated through wickedness, and of so much more, this great, ancient elder. But here's an interesting question: why did he go to visit death? He could have lived, created, spoken about life, but instead he chose to descend into Hades, to bring his wisest concerns to speak with death itself, and to see the thread of sinners — to question Sisyphus and Tantalus, to look upon Achilles and Hector, the great heroism of the damned. And to find out, for certain, whether it isn't life that's death, or death that's life, of human existence. And so, the question is: did he find out? And where is he now, that great champion of spiritual contemplation? Maybe he's been boiling in a cauldron for a long time now, in some fiery, stinking pit; or maybe he's not there at all, but arguing with Hades, doing good, explaining to the devils what heat surely awaits them, forgiving them, soothing them with Paradise, changing their very

features — just as hatred twists a face, so forgiveness smooths it out again. Socrates's words heal sickness the way medicine defeats pain; the demons drop their old work and listen to Socrates's prose. Hades saw this and rushed off straight to Zeus, up on Olympus, begging: "Supreme one, hurry, take Socrates away, up to the halls of paradise, because I can already hear the footsteps of Revolution, and Hades isn't what it used to be — you can hear brushstrokes of virtue everywhere now, and this is supposed to be a purgatory for scoundrels, for the fallen, ignorant beasts, a quarry along Olympus's own road." Zeus heard the word and said, "Bring him here to me, quickly, before he stirs up more trouble, and I have to deal with demons all over again, throwing lightning bolts down from the clouds." And so Socrates was brought, right there, face to face with Zeus. "Well, Socrates, wisest of men, answer Zeus quickly: why do you go poking your nose where it doesn't belong? You, the great God, the Creator — answer me, if you can, why did you create my knowledge of Socrates, if not so that I could know my own essence?" "You speak the truth," Zeus said, "but you will submit to the law nonetheless, or Hades, completely out of patience, might set off a great explosion and decide to play games with you." To which Socrates, of course, objected, and asked for just a little — to visit the lands of the living stars again, to keep practicing his wisdom, to keep digging for the essence of things. To which Zeus, naturally, explained: "The essence cannot be known through knowing" — but he

smiled a gentle smile as he said it. "Even the gods don't know the truth. But we'll find you a little tour, of course, of the lands of Paradise's wandering, and there will be plenty to occupy you there – wisdom, truth, legend. Though even they don't know the essence of their own existence, only the laws of their own motion, their colors, their moods, their adventures." "There, Socrates, my friend, you will never understand this life – I break my own golden curls over it myself, over who I am and where my home is, whether life is death, or death is life, who created Kronos, who gave birth to the boundless Cosmos. So go on, Socrates, take a walk – here is my confession to you, my own disappointment as the Supreme God."

Mama

Mama, I've wanted to write these lines for a long time, to dedicate a poem to you, my dear one – how much I love you, how hard you push yourself, protecting me from every misfortune, how much you wear yourself down for me. Your soul tears itself apart from grief; you love so grandly, my dear one, your own child, your own flesh and blood, the little drop of the world that is your own. Mama, my dear mama, I will protect you from bullets; I am your shield, your guard, I am your Guardian of peace, the one who brings you goodness and warmth. I want to cry so badly when you're upset, when you're clouded over, because of what I've done, my own hardships. But Mama, remember your son's words: I am

a knight against life's cruelties, I am the white knight of this life, bound to protect you, and ready for it. And I say this to you from the heart: I want to forge chains for you — chains of joy and delight — just as Prometheus chained himself, breaking every rule, sacrificing himself for the world. And I am something like a hero too, performing the right rite of the soul, the decent conduct of a life. And know, my dear, sweet mama, how badly I want to build you an Acapulco — a resort, a paradise, all in one estate, a blessed island just for you, because you deserve the greatest honor, you are the best in the world to me, the light of the Great Fire, you are the Mother of God to me.

Woman

Oh woman, the Great Game, soaking in the very depth of existence; oh Eve, who betrayed the Creator, condemning the entire human race to torment. Man was cast out of Paradise, nakedness now brings shame, labor is nothing but punishment, and sin is the cause of all of it. Oh woman, who betrayed me, you defeated Adam so skillfully, just with the right words, the foundation of a serpent's wisdom. Well, if a woman is to blame for all of it, the source of every disappointment, then what am I supposed to do, a descendant of sinful Adam? Oh woman, the foundation of ruin, you know how to defeat me, to ensnare me, to charm me, to break every code. Oh woman, sinful soul, who submits while conquering — how much I love you, I bow down on my knees before

you, I curse you forever, oh woman who betrayed me, you tricked me, led me straight into torment. Oh woman, who split the Creator apart — good and evil, once, like a vessel filled to the brim. You conceive life alongside death; you too live through your own torment; your own fate torments you, and the memory of exile from Paradise probably destroys you, endlessly. Oh woman, how frightening you are, how dangerous you can be — surely the serpent opened your eyes, and now you know everything about me, you've been given the keys to the warehouse where all my affairs are stored, my thoughts, my feelings, my desires. Oh woman, how strong you are — you hold good and evil in your cheeks and hand them out, laughing, playing your own game of cat and mouse. Oh woman, made from a rib, why don't you repent for what you've done, why don't you look for a way out for yourself, why don't you listen to God? Oh woman who betrayed me, you keep feeding that serpent, endlessly, the one who feeds on blood, and thoughts of your betrayal of me give birth to incomprehensible deeds. Oh woman, vessel of sin, you gave birth to vice like a child, you love it, you cherish that offspring, which grows and demands more. Betrayal, the color of gold and fur. And what about you, Adam? You love God, don't you — the Father, the Creator of the earthly cycle — so why aren't you looking for the way back? Oh tree, of good and of evil, what exactly are you? What forbidden thing do you hold within you — maybe terrible concepts, maybe you're the one who let death loose into our world? Oh

Bible, the foundation of our existence, you have no answer for me, only questions and riddles that never seem to end. Oh God, how sad it all is, why is everything so trivial; oh God, take me back, I will be a faithful Adam again, and the garden of Eden will return, and I will change Eve's understanding, and we will find every answer, if we return to God, ask for forgiveness and shelter under Paradise's care. Because we are children of our Father, and we will be washed clean by his love.

Conversation with Death

I saw death, the shackles of life, how the chains fell from my own soul, and the thread of a living man held in death's own burning hand. The soul screams out in pain: "Oh God, how dark it is, how frightening this creature looks, the one who has come for me. What a grip, God, how strong — it pulls my soul along with it into unimaginably distant realms." It stays silent, and it hurts me. "How badly it burns, in my heart, how frightening — wait, where are you dragging my soul, where are you leading me — wait, what torment am I condemned to? Or maybe I should try to run, outwit death the way the ancients did — Sisyphus once chained it for good." But of course, I'm no favorite of God; I don't have tricks like that at my disposal. But I gathered my willpower and spoke to death about myself, about eternal life, about the prophets, about the laws of existence, about Moses, Abraham, and Christ — I had questions of my own. And unexpectedly, I heard a word:

"I am Death, a messenger of existence, a herald of eternal power. I hold the keys to life, the right to you, and to any soul that has come to the fire because of sin, or that needs my hand to shake off the unclean, the small, unnecessary things in which a person's thoughts get stuck — a person who has a fate. I am not only the Herald of death; I carry life too, in a beautiful casket. I subtract days, years, centuries; I carry the living waters of time and life beneath my own heart. And you will still be, for a little while, a student in my affairs. But remember this for certain: I am a great herald, meant for you — you are forgiven, Hades will not take you in, purgatory has washed your heels clean, your particles of God, tangled golden domes. From now on, you will not be who you were; your breath is the eternal fire, a lamp of a sage's enlightenment, the foundation of a happy ending." At this point in the world, whose edges are unknown to it, a fantasy for your era, the riddle of life, of death, of existence — I don't know exactly what to call it, but death has touched me, and I understood the foundation of the world, of my own existence beyond the grave. And how am I supposed to judge this crisis — enlightenment, or delirium? A fracture, creating labyrinths of the world, asking the question: who, really, am I? And Death, with the smile of God, struck me with its black staff, taking life after life, the ones that belong to death, the demon of a wild consciousness, the great, dark, ancient tempter of man, and of himself. Everything is abundant in this world, and at the same time, everything is emptiness;

day and night wage endless war; the tide, ebbing and flowing, reshapes the world; earth and sky tear a person apart; motion is always present — the beginning, the center, and the fading of the beginning of the Great End, of the infinite instant. And there is only one path:

**Know yourself,
and nothing in excess —
that's what Death taught me,
(translated from the Ukrainian)**

When you, Cossack, are taken into captivity, unexpectedly, hold on as tightly as you can, because captivity is a cursed prison, where there are no human moments, where the master is worse than any devil, where your schedule is the regime, a strict cycle governing your every minute, where they train you to submit. And you can lose your own honor here, because here, other concepts rule — this too is a war, a battlefield, for honor, for freedom, for life. You will fight, you will bleed; you will live down in the pit, because Cossacks who live like people have no right to live like the Russian scum, to crawl like swine, when you're beaten and driven like a herd, like a dumb calf that has no right to its own life. Because in the pit, they gather all the young men who know what freedom really is, what suffering means for a hero, who respect themselves with honor and strength, for not bowing to the Khan, for holding onto their Ukrainian identity to the end. When you don't bend, don't hunch your back before the red

master of your life, who has ears even in the walls – there are no informants, no borders here, so hold your thoughts close, all of them; don't trust, don't fear, and stand your ground – that's my advice for life. And the kozel, placed there by the red khan, will peck at you from morning on, will tell you to bow down and submit, or else he'll write a complaint against you, and you'll be sent to isolation for years. But don't be afraid, take this advice: strike, break these cursed shackles – they're only held together by spit. And if you have to, let loose a golden rain on this little parasite of the land, this so-called "helper of the authorities" – that's the lowest rank in this whole mess. Hold on, brother – we did the same before you, broke the horns of the foolish goat, and then suffered for it in the pit ourselves, but, my brave boy, that's when people recognize you, because you're brave, little one, and you hold your honor to the end, and you don't bend your neck under the yoke, and your voice sounds the way it should – you are free, you are a person of honor, you fight to the end. But watch yourself, look at the edges, because the fiercest enemy is Judas – he sees everything, and he calculates. But you, Cossack, be smarter – hide all your business, you alone are responsible for holding it together, keep everything wrapped in mystery, because the falcon flies high and chooses its own heron. So turn, watch, the way you should – let one ear sleep while the other stands guard. Look others in the eye, because that is the mirror of the soul, because words can say one thing and swear by

every god, and still lie to you – that's how con artists operate, their eyes darting like turpentine in the wind; they can't look you in the eye, and their gestures are like sea foam, giving away everything they're really doing. You have to master reading all these little signs of trouble, and only then will you become a true warrior – your gear is your own actions, deeds that carry real value, because all deeds are washed in blood, your cross of a brave man's suffering, the one who never bowed to the red khan of this land.

Judas

I sit in a storm, a captured hero; Judas's dogs guard my burning. Betrayal chases me in circles; my whip is trust, turned against me. What gave birth to a young man's betrayal – someone who doesn't understand life, for whom trust is worth nothing? Just as Judas betrayed Jesus for thirty pieces of silver, so this man betrayed every promise, out of the basest of concerns, just to fill his stomach for entertainment, just to buy himself a little more time, staining his own name forever, to be called a dog until the end of time. I wonder what Judas actually felt on his great, black day. And you – what are you thinking, you dog? Know this: retribution is the law. Judas hanged himself in spiritual agony, having understood his terrible sin. And what have you decided, you dog? Remember: forgiveness loves only bloody sweat.

My Game

Currents of life, the difference in potential – without cold, there can be no heat, what's above can never take the place of what's below, and death cannot buy its way into life. This is no fantastical inside knowledge, just the labyrinth, the circle of samsara. Whoever understands the wholeness of the monad and reconciles the night with the light, understands the way out of the wheel of samsara, and calls life a game. Trouble comes to the one who fails to see life as an adventure for the hunter, and evil as just the sharp edge of the circle. Let the Demon into your mouth, and the hellish shard within Paradise will destroy paradise itself. And evil – it's only half of the circle, the half that splits ordinary life down the middle.



WHAT'S NEXT

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